银线结
Silver Knot

目录 / Contents

银厅的诘问 / Queries in the Hall 2
象牙塔尖 / Top of the Ivory Tower 8
寄生蜂群 / Parasites 13
兔与龟 / Tortoise and the Hare 20
学者于雪海 / The Researcher in Snow 30
泡沫之下 / After the Bubble Bursts 36
守夜人 / The Night Keeper 46
同行者 / Companions 51

银厅的诘问
Queries in the Hall CH18603-01

Lecture Hall, Laplace
拉普拉斯科算中心演讲厅

Windsong: 1, 2, 3, and 4. Good. They're all here.
北方哨歌：1，2，3……4，很好，都在这里。

Windsong sets aside the notes in her hand. It's still too early for anyone to have arrived at the lecture hall.
北方哨歌放下手中的演讲稿，抬眼望着空无一人的演讲大厅。

Windsong: So cold in here. And there's a different shade of gray to this place compared to Rayashki. Even the "lines" in this room seem sharp enough to slice off the tips of my fingers if I dared touch them.
北方哨歌：从雪白，到银灰……这里给人的感觉比来亚什基更冰冷，连“线”也锋利得多，仿佛我动动指尖，它就会削下我整根手指。

Windsong: *sigh*
北方哨歌：唉……

She holds her wrist with her other hand in an attempt to steady its uncontrollable trembling. This always happens when she's nervous.
北方哨歌轻轻扼住了自己的手腕，它正因紧张带来的交感神经系统过于活跃而微微颤抖。

Windsong: Now breathe, Windsong.
北方哨歌：深呼吸，北方哨歌同志。

She draws in a long breath, feeling the crisp air fill her lungs.
深吸一口气，一股不存在的寒风灌满了鼻腔，直抵肺的最深处。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

It brings back a vivid memory of Rayashki.
来亚什基，仍在她的记忆里。

Port, Rayashki
来亚什基·码头

Resident I: Are you leaving already, Comrade Windsong?
镇民 I：您这就出发吗，北方哨歌同志？

Windsong: I'm afraid so. Lots to do and so little time to do it. If everything goes smoothly there, I might be able to return before the kids come back from the Foundation.
北方哨歌：是的。事情多，日程又紧——顺利的话，我也许能赶在孩子们从基金会回来之前返回。

Resident I: Off for a publicity tour for Rayashki, eh? Make sure you tell them about all the wonderful things we have here!
镇民 I：您要去向那些人宣传我们的来亚什基吗？请多帮我们说点好话呀！

Resident II: Yes! They must come and try our Ukha and the potato stew, too!
镇民 II：让他们来尝尝我们的鳜鱼汤和土豆炖菜！

Resident I: Speaking of which, have you prepared anything for the road, Comrade Windsong?
镇民 I：对了！您路上有吃的吗，北方哨歌同志？

These words are like a signal. Suddenly, a plethora of packages are thrust into her arms from all directions.
这句话如同按下了发射器的开关。

Windsong: Oh!
北方哨歌：噢……！

Before long, her arms are filled with cheeses of all shapes and sizes.
不用一会儿，怀里便接满了形状各异的——奶酪。

Windsong: Thank you, thank you all. This is a generous amount of cheese for one trip.
北方哨歌：真是感谢……但这实在有些太多了……

Resident II: Hah, I see what you're getting at. Of course, we can't have you eating nothing but cheese the whole time!
镇民 II：是啊，难道让北方哨歌同志一路上只吃奶酪吗？

More packages are shoved into her arms.
很快，北方哨歌的怀里又被塞进了各式各样的东西。

Beetroot, a large ham, a portable gas stove, and a lonely wool sock.
红菜头、火腿、便携煤气炉，和有且仅有一只的麂皮袜子。

Resident I: Take care, Comrade Windsong!
镇民 I：一路顺利啊！北方哨歌同志！

Crowd: Safe journey, Comrade Windsong!
镇民众：一路顺利！

The steamship horn sounds, echoing across the bay to the mountains in the distance. They stand tall and gray, the silent guardians of the town and its people.
汽笛声轰鸣，这悠长又空旷的声音引得北方哨歌望向驾驶室，远方的山峦不为所动。

In the lingering echo of the horn, the ship departs from the dock. Windsong looks back at the shore; the people of Rayashki are still there, waving to her. She manages a wave in return.
轮船缓缓驶去，镇民们仍热情地向北方哨歌招着手，北方哨歌腾出一只手来，示意镇民们快些回去。

The wind becomes more biting, and the snow stings her face. She waves until the town and its people fade from sight and heads to the cabin with her luggage.
海风裹挟着雪粒，渐渐地，连来亚什基都看不见了，北方哨歌这才拎起手提箱，回到了船舱中。

She remembers traversing lands covered in snow and lush vegetation, passing the towering mountains and the open bay. She changed from ship to train, from train to car, and despite her best efforts to keep the cheese wrappers intact, they started to fall apart.
雪原、海峡、山地、平原，轮船、火车、汽车、步行，北方哨歌口袋里的奶酪早就变得瘫软。

Just like her memories of Rayashki.
它们已经是为数不多的，来亚什基确实存在过的证明。

Her heart sinks at the thought of that little town. The entire place gone, and these cheeses some of the last things left to prove it ever existed. She takes out one of the packages, takes a small bite, and carefully wraps it back up.
北方哨歌撕开包装，却只轻轻咬了一小口。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: Heh, Windsong, still believe you have a home to return to.
北方哨歌：瞧我，还不死心地以为有人在等着我回去呢……

She runs her fingers over the wrinkled wax paper.
北方哨歌抚摸着充满褶皱的锡纸包装。

Windsong: ...!
北方哨歌：……！

She rubs her face and straightens up.
半晌，她揉揉眼睛，又拍拍脸颊。

Windsong: Come on. Not now. You've got a speech to give.
北方哨歌：得了，这不是现在该想的事。

Windsong: Let's see. I'll start with a brief introduction of myself, then move on to the history of the study of ley lines, followed by ... Hmm.
北方哨歌：首先是自我介绍，接下来是理线学的历史，然后是……

Windsong: They may have some questions on environmental analysis for me. Or, perhaps, they'll ask about the geological conditions in Rayashki.
北方哨歌：他们可能会问理线学跟环境分析学结合的相关问题，也可能会问来亚什基的地质情况。

Windsong: Better to keep the geologic map handy. Here it is.
北方哨歌：地质图也在这里，需要的时候随时能用得上。

Windsong: What else will they want to know? The nature of ley energy—that could be one.
北方哨歌：还可能会问什么？跟理线学相关的……哦，地脉能量的基本原理。

She hears some indistinct chatter coming from the end of the hallway.
走廊里传来了模糊不清的回声，音节已经因为无数次反射而变得无法辨认，这是人们即将分食空旷的前奏。

Windsong: Hm?
北方哨歌：嗯……?

She stares at the door. The muffled arguments quickly become clearer, and soon two researchers in Laplace uniforms step inside.
北方哨歌紧紧地盯着门口，随着声源的靠近，两位身着拉普拉斯制服的研究员踏入了演讲大厅的门。

Researcher I: Look, I don't want to be mean, but I brought this to you a long time ago. You were very —
研究员 I： 我早就和你讨论过这个问题，你那时候还说什么……

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

The argument comes to a sudden halt as they lay eyes on her.
当他们看到北方哨歌时，四目相对，话题也戛然而止。

Windsong: Welcome, comrades. Are you both here for the lecture? Please take a seat. Make yourselves comfortable.
北方哨歌：欢迎，同志，是来参加理线学的讲座的吗？请随便坐。

She gestures toward the chairs, but one of them walks straight up to her.
北方哨歌做出了“请”的手势，但其中一名研究员直直向她走来。

Researcher I: Are you giving the lecture today? Are you the ley hunter?
研究员 I： 你就是这次的主讲人吗？一名理线师?

Windsong: What gave it away? You can call me Windsong.
北方哨歌：是的，您可以叫我北方哨歌。

Researcher I: A ley hunter in real life!
研究员 I： ……一位实际存在的“理线师”!

He leans toward her, as if inspecting a specimen in a glass case. Before Windsong can react, he speaks again.
研究员像是要仔细观察玻璃后的藏品一般将身体探了过去，不等北方哨歌反应，他便开了口。

Researcher I: May I ask you a few questions?
研究员 I： 可以询问你几个问题吗?

Researcher I: Why are you still studying ley lines?
研究员 I： 为什么你仍在研究理线学?

Windsong: Hm?
北方哨歌： 嗯?

Windsong: Because ...
北方哨歌： 因为……

She opens her notebook, but it provides her with no answer.
北方哨歌： 北方哨歌下意识去翻准备好的材料，但这上面并没有这个问题的答案。

Researcher I: That can't possibly be your major project, can it? So what is it, then? Geology? Environmental planning?
研究员 I： 你应该不是只研究理线学吧？你的主课题是什么？地质相关的？还是规划类的?

Windsong: No, I ...
北方哨歌： 不，我……

Her only study has been, and will always be, that of ley lines.
只有理线学。

Researcher I: Only the study of ley lines?
研究员 I： 只研究理线学?

Windsong: Yes.
北方哨歌： 是的。

She's relieved that she can finally give a positive response.
北方哨歌终于能够给予自己的听众一个肯定的答案。

But the two researchers exchange a bewildered look.
但两名研究员疑惑地对视了一眼。

Researcher II: But, Ms. Windsong, I don't think there's much research or many studies concerning ley lines these days—well, there aren't any, if we're honest. Who's funding it? Are there any ongoing projects or publications?
研究员 II： 北方哨歌女士，可是我们平常没有见到过和理线学相关的项目或者课题……你的资金来源是什么呢？有研究方向和产出吗?

Researcher I: I haven't seen any studies that included ley lines in their research. Is the study of ley lines considered a scientific discipline or more of an arcane one? Which journals or publishers do you usually send your papers to?
研究员 I： 我几乎没有在期刊上见过理线学参与的文章，说到底，它究竟算科学还是神秘学？有期刊愿意接收你的论文吗?

Researcher II: And what made you stick with it?
研究员 II： 为什么你还在坚持研究理线学呢?

Windsong responds with a bitter smile.
北方哨歌尴尬地笑了笑。

Windsong: Well, it's a long story.
北方哨歌： 真是个答案显而易见、缘由又足够复杂的问题……

She hears more footsteps coming down the hallway.
脚步声再次零零散散地从走廊里传来。

Researcher III: ...
研究员 III： ……

Researcher IV: Mm?
研究员 IV： 嗯?

One after another, researchers file into the lecture hall.
一位，两位……赶来参加讲座的研究员们鱼贯而入。

Windsong feels the curious eyes of some as they pass by.
他们之中偶尔会有人用好奇的目光打量演讲台附近三人。

Researcher V & VI: ...
研究员 V & 研究员 VI： ……

Most, however, take their seats quietly.
但更多的是直接入座，等待着讲座的开始。

Windsong: Why don't you go join the others? We'll be starting any minute.
北方哨歌： 请先入座吧，讲座开始的时间也快到了。

The researcher nods and steps back from the podium. He finds a seat at the front, placing his notebook on the table before him. Windsong meets his eager eyes.
研究员离开了演讲台，坐到离北方哨歌最近的位置上，拿出了笔记本，表情专注地望着北方哨歌。

Researcher I: Would you share with us how you got into this field of study?
研究员 I： 也许你可以从刚接触理线学时开始讲起。

His friend also takes a seat in the first row.
他的同伴也随之坐到了他的旁边，等待着讲座的开始。

The murmurs lower as more and more are seated. Windsong takes a bracing breath and rings the bell on the podium.
人们的低语沉淀在了大厅的底部，北方哨歌稍微整理了一下情绪，摇响了手中的铜铃。

The lights dim. All eyes are focused on her.
观众席的灯光暗了下来，人们将注意力聚集在了北方哨歌的身上。

Microphone: Buzzz ...
麦克风： 滋滋——

Windsong: Ahem. Sorry.
北方哨歌： 咳咳。不好意思。

Windsong: Welcome, comrades, fellow researchers. It is an honor to be here to share some ideas in the study of ley lines with you.
北方哨歌： 各位同志，各位……同仁，欢迎大家来参加今天的理线学讲座。

The crowd responds with sparse clapping.
掌声稀稀落落地响着。

Windsong: My name is Windsong. I'm a ley hunter. Our topic today is ...
北方哨歌： 我是这次讲座的主讲人北方哨歌，今天讲座的主题是——

Windsong: "Ley Lines in Environmental Analysis: A Geological Survey of Rayashki."
北方哨歌： “来亚什基：理线学与环境分析学集成视角下的地质勘测”。

She taps the keyboard, and the topic emerges on the projector screen.
北方哨歌敲了一下演讲台旁的键盘，一行标题出现在墙上的幕布中。

Windsong: Some of you may have heard of the study of ley lines, while for others it may be a novelty. Although not a new discovery, ley lines are unfortunately given little attention in today's academia.
北方哨歌：提起理线学，在座的各位也许会陌生，也许会新奇……但遗憾的是，它远远称不上是位年轻的新朋友。

Windsong: Its study emerged in the early 20th century and, for the next 50 years, played an auxiliary role in other disciplines—geography, biology, even applied physics. It helped many researchers in various fields, but its value in and of itself was underrated.
北方哨歌：理线学初创于 20 世纪初，在长达五十余年的时间里都埋没在浩如烟海的学派众说里。它是地理学、生物学，甚至应用物理学的边角料，而唯独不仅仅是它自己。

Windsong: It was a desperate time. That was until Comrade Tristan Lisov came along.
北方哨歌：那是一幕漫长的夜晚……直到特里斯坦·莱索夫同志的到来。

Windsong: He is the genius that every discipline dreams of having. In no more than ten years, he brought the study to its peak.
北方哨歌：天才总是令人嫉妒的，他以短短不到十年的时间将理线学推上了从未有过的高峰。

Windsong: "The 21st century belongs to the study of ley lines," he said.
北方哨歌：他告诉我们：“21 世纪，将会是理线学的世纪。”

Windsong: Just like many other ley hunters, I was deeply encouraged by his words.
北方哨歌：对我来说，不止是我，也许对很多投身过理线学的人来说，这都是一句令他们感触颇深的话。

Windsong: Like a fire smoldering under the ashes, they got us through those hopeless times.
北方哨歌：它就像是一枚阴燃的火种，让理线师们那段骄傲却难以追悼的人生熠熠生光。

She scans the faces lit by the projection screen, hoping to see their reactions.
北方哨歌扫视着台下观众晦暗不清的脸，想要从他们的表情上获取到一些他们对理线学态度的信息。

She notices the first researcher's face. His eyes are fixed on her as he tries to understand where the story is going.
而人群之中最显眼的，是那个坐得离她最近的研究员，他一直盯着北方哨歌，想凭借她的话语来解开自己的疑惑。

Researcher I: Would you share with us how you got into this field of study?
研究员 I：也许你可以从刚接触理线学时开始讲起。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: Before we get into more detail, I have a question for you all.
北方哨歌：在开始今天的正题之前，我想先问大家一个问题。

Windsong: When it comes to a school of thought, who do you need more—those that get the work done or the ones that make it popular?
北方哨歌：对于一个学派来说，是埋头研究的人更重要，还是长袖善舞的人更加重要?

Windsong: Don't worry. Take some time to think about it, and I'll come back to it at the end.
北方哨歌：没关系，我并不是要大家现在就给出答案，大家可以一边听讲座一边想。

Windsong: As I said earlier, I was enthralled by Lisov's enthusiasm and ambition and became a ley hunter. It was a remarkable time; under his guidance, we all had unwavering faith in this discipline.
北方哨歌：还记得那句满怀着希望和豪情的话吗？它确实成了我入行的契机。那时，我和我的同僚们都坚信着理线学有着光明的未来。

8#1
8#1

象牙塔尖
Top of the Ivory Tower CH18603-02

A simple world is an ignorant one.
过于纯净的世界代表了你的蒙昧。

You may have grown accustomed to its ignorance, so much so that you don't see it anymore, like how your brain filters the nose from your sight.
你已经完全适应，融为芸芸众生，如同眼睛已经忽视了鼻子。

Stretch your arms and legs. Roll your neck. Feel your blood flowing and your heart beating, and follow the passion within.
你可以先从感受血液的流动开始做起，听听心脏的跳动，感受活塞时刻都在面对的汹涌。

At first, all you have are your primitive instincts. Your senses are overwhelmed by the vastness of the world. There's so much information to be absorbed. It's scary, but also intriguing. Ripples collide and rebound, overlap, and intertwine.
起先，是纷杂的涟漪，万物都在对你发出尖叫，碰撞与回弹，重叠又交错，这很好，这并不是它们抗拒你的象征。

You can't ignore them anymore. You must find a way to communicate with them.
你忽视它们太久了，你要试着告诉他们，什么才是合适你的音量。

But to where do they flow?
接下来……它们流去哪里了?

Ley Lines Institute
理线学研究所

Windsong: *vomit*
北方哨歌：……呕！

She opens her eyes to find herself kneeling on the marble floor. She hears people's voices and knows that she has come back to reality.
用菱形将白色和棕色分割的大理石上沾上了北方哨歌的胆汁，嘈杂的环境让北方哨歌确认自己已经回来。

Old Nikola: Don't move! Stay where you are!
老尼古拉：不要动！对对！就保持这个姿势！

Windsong: *vomiting continues* Wh-what?
北方哨歌：呕——什、什么?

Old Nikola: No! What have you done?!
老尼古拉：不！你做了什么！

Windsong: Nothing!
北方哨歌：我没有动！

Old Nikola: Nothing?! The experiment's ruined thanks to you! And what did I say about the electron ground-state line? Why don't you just go to the admissions office and re-enroll as a novice? Perhaps if you do your studies again, you'll actually learn a thing or two!
老尼古拉：你把实验样品毁了！我早就跟你说过，别动那条能影响电子基态的线！滚回到新人那里去从零学起吧！

"Bang!"
“哐！”

Windsong: Mm?
北方哨歌：嗯?

Although muffled, his roaring continues on the other side of the door.
声音在门关上之后变得失真了许多。

???: Go! We're running this again!
???: 再来！

She stares at the door.
北方哨歌愣愣地看向声源的位置。

Windsong: He really does have a booming voice. I can still hear him as clear as day.
北方哨歌: 五米的距离……真是有力气……呵……

Windsong: *breathing uncomfortably*
北方哨歌: 呼……呼……哈。

She's still not used to the side effects of tracing ley lines.
探寻地脉的副作用仍需要花些时间才能摆脱。

Professor Ivanov: Haha, don't take it to heart, comrade Ekaterina. It's not personal. He's always been the loudest one in the room.
伊万诺夫教授: 哈哈，原谅老尼古拉吧，瓦莲京娜同志，他并不是在呵责你，他的嗓门一向都是这么大。

Windsong: Ah, Professor.
北方哨歌: 啊……

Professor Ivanov walks over and gives her a gentle pat on the shoulder.
教授从身侧走来，友好地拍了拍北方哨歌的肩。

Professor Ivanov: Are you okay?
伊万诺夫教授: 你还好吗?

A janitor quickly arrives to clean up the mess on the floor. This is clearly not the first time this has happened.
跟着教授一起来的还有清洁工，他们司空见惯一般擦去了北方哨歌的呕吐物。

Windsong shakes her head, trying to clear her mind.
北方哨歌晃了晃脑袋，试图向对面传达某种肯定的情绪。

Windsong: Sorry, Professor. I was a bit lost in there.
北方哨歌: 抱歉，我刚才走神了，教授。

Professor Ivanov: Don't worry, it wasn't easy for any of us on our first try. A good experience, though, wouldn't you agree?
伊万诺夫教授: 别担心，第一次大家多少都会有些“不良反应”……但那是非常有意思的旅行，对吗?

Windsong: Yes. I, I saw lines, each in different shapes and colors. Some were straight—in rigid patterns—while others looked like a jumble of fibers. Were those the ley lines?
北方哨歌: 是的。我……我看到了很多条线，不同的颜色，直的和曲的，规律的和杂乱的……这就是能量线……

She extends a tentative finger into the air, tracing what she just saw.
北方哨歌颤抖着伸出了手指，将空气中的什么东西轻轻地拨到了一边。

Professor Ivanov: Don't run before you can walk, Comrade Ekaterina. Remember, there could be serious consequences if we tamper with ley lines without knowing their sources.
伊万诺夫教授: 先别这么着急实践，瓦莲京娜同志。在没有追溯到能量线的源头之前，无心的拨动只会埋下隐患。

Windsong: Yes, Professor Ivanov.
北方哨歌: 好的，伊万诺夫教授。

She withdraws her hand, but she can still feel the energy of the lines swirling around her.
她迅速收回了手，但仍旧痴迷地感受着周围的能量线。

Professor Ivanov: Once you know every ley line by heart, you'll be able to play them like a heptachord. Do you remember what I said in class?
伊万诺夫教授：等你记住每种物体的能量线排列之后，你就可以快乐地弹起这把“七弦琴”了，还记得我之前说过的吗?

Windsong: Yes. We can briefly transform one thing into another by changing the attributes of their ley lines, but the object's nature remains unchanged. The study of ley lines is the discipline of observation, and the ley hunters' job is to observe, not to create, intervene, or impose our will on nature.
北方哨歌：改变能量线的排列，能暂时将一种物体改变成另一种……但它终究会回归本质，因为理线学是一门观察的学科，我们去了解，我们无法插手。

Professor Ivanov: Exactly. Never intervene. But we might find the way out for others. By revealing the hidden clues in nature, we can lead them to the right path.
伊万诺夫教授：但我们能够带领他人前行。

Windsong: Lead them to the right path.
北方哨歌：带领他人前行……

She repeats his words under her breath.
北方哨歌喃喃地重复着。

How many days and nights has she spent studying to become a ley hunter at this institute? All her efforts are finally paying off.
为了今天，她已经不知道熬过了多少个日夜，才勉强能从众多应试者中考入这所理线学的研究所。

Old Nikola: I told you before! This is our last sample! The last one!
老尼古拉：我先前讲过！这是最后一份样品！最后一份！

Junior Researcher I: Ah. Could you give me a hand, sir? My fingers seem to be stuck.
初级研究员 Ⅰ：不……请帮帮我，老师，我把手指完全陷进去了。

Old Nikola: The lab report! The lab report!! The lab report!!! What are those ears on the sides of your head for, decoration?!
老尼古拉：实验报告！实验报告！实验报告！您没听见吗?

Junior Researcher II: Yes, the white board. Bring it to Room 302A.
初级研究员 Ⅱ：是的，白板，302A 会议室要用到。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Professor Ivanov: Still feeling strange, huh? Everyone in this place is caught up with their own hectic schedules. You'll find your place in this institution once you've decided on your research topic.
伊万诺夫教授：还很不适应，是吗？研究所的人们都很忙，忙到形成了一种奇特的韵律……等你开始了自己的课题之后，你也会是这里的一个声部。

Windsong: And when will that be, Professor?
北方哨歌：那我什么时候能开始做课题呢，教授?

Professor Ivanov: Haha.
伊万诺夫教授：哈哈……

He shakes his head, still smiling.
教授笑着摇了摇头。

Professor Ivanov: Take it easy; there's no need to rush. Besides, it seems your colleagues are still struggling to catch up with you, Comrade Ekaterina.
伊万诺夫教授：等等你的同僚吧，瓦莲京娜同志。

He gestures behind her.
伊万诺夫教授向北方哨歌的身后指去。

A number of junior researchers are sprawled out in the hallway, lying or leaning in recovery from what they just experienced.
一些和北方哨歌一样年轻的初级研究员们正各自使用自己最舒服的姿势躺或倚在走廊里。

At one end of the hallway, two medical staff quietly wheel one of them out on a stretcher.
走廊尽头，两名医护人员悄悄地抬走了某位不太适应地脉能量的倒霉蛋。

Professor Ivanov: Are there any projects you find particularly interesting? The one on the Kolaria Superdeep Borehole? Or maybe the Sverdlovsk rescue group?
伊万诺夫教授：你已经有心仪的项目了吗？“科拉利亚超深钻井计划”或者“斯维尔德罗夫斯克救援小组”……

Professor Ivanov: Those two are quite prominent. They're making good progress, and the higher-ups are fairly supportive of them. I think they'd suit you well.
伊万诺夫教授：这两个都是很不错的，有“上面”的支持，项目正处于高速发展的时期，于你们也是很适合的。

Windsong: No ... I ...
北方哨歌：不……我想……

Windsong: I'm quite interested in that one. Are they still taking new members?
北方哨歌：我想去看看那个项目，可以吗？

Old Nikola: Has it ever occurred to you that we have safety regulations to follow here?!
老尼古拉：你到底知不知道什么是实验室安全管理制度！

Professor Ivanov: Ah. Old Nik's project. Do you know what he's working on?
伊万诺夫教授：哦……老尼古拉的项目，你知道他在研究什么吗？

Windsong: Not really. But the pile of papers on his desk is impressive. Looks like the old guy's trying to build his own tower of Babel.
北方哨歌：不知道，但是那边的资料堆得很高。

Professor Ivanov: Don't you want to join one of the more high-profile projects?
伊万诺夫教授：你不想去看看那几个知名度高的项目吗？

Windsong looks over at the researchers sitting in the opposite corner, each fully absorbed in their work.
北方哨歌看向远处沉寂着的研究员们。

It's the most comfortable corner in the building, and the people sitting there are the true elites of the establishment.
他们坐在研究所里阳光最好的位置上，是名副其实的精英。

Windsong: That one looks more fun.
北方哨歌：老尼古拉那边看起来似乎有趣一些。

Professor Ivanov: Alright.
伊万诺夫教授：好吧。

Professor Ivanov: There'll be a staff restructuring in six months. If you end up regretting your decision, there's still a chance we could put you in a different group. Not many people can put up with Old Nik, you know.
伊万诺夫教授：如果你后悔的话，半年后有一次调任的机会——很少有人会一直在老尼古拉手底下干下去。

Windsong: Why?
北方哨歌：因为什么?

Old Nikola: Group meeting, Room 105, 8 p.m.!
老尼古拉：晚上 8 点，去 105 开组会！

Professor Ivanov: Haha, well ...
伊万诺夫教授：是啊，为什么呢……

Old Nikola: Who "ley-lined" my coffee into this thing?!
老尼古拉：谁用“理线”把我的咖啡变成这个鬼样子了！

No one wants to admit to such a basic mistake. The room falls into a deadly silence.
因为一个低级又不专业的错误被展露在众人的眼前，研究所一下子安静了下来。

Old Nikola: Come on! Which one of you rookies just messed with the ley lines in the room?!
老尼古拉：你们这群菜鸟，谁刚才乱动能量线了?!

Windsong: Hmm?
北方哨歌：唔……?!

She tucks her hands behind her back.
北方哨歌急忙把手背到后面去，而这一举动正巧透露出她刚才做了什么。

Professor Ivanov: Perfect timing, Old Nik! Meet Comrade Ekaterina. She's going to fill the vacancy in your group.
伊万诺夫教授：老尼古拉，你来得正好，这位是新来的瓦莲京娜同志，正好可以补上你们组的空缺。

Old Nikola: Hmph.
老尼古拉：哼……

His sharp gaze locks onto her. Windsong feels as though nothing can escape his sight.
老尼古拉审视着北方哨歌，眼神锐利得仿佛他已经通过能量线将北方哨歌整个人都看透。

Windsong: Urh. That wasn't me. I mean the coffee, I think.
北方哨歌：咖啡的事……我想……也许不是我做的?

Old Nikola: Hmph.
老尼古拉：哼。

Windsong senses a smirk lurking behind his beard.
老尼古拉用胡子笑了一下。

Old Nikola: Follow me, rookie.
老尼古拉：跟我过来吧，菜鸟。

He turns on his heels and starts marching away.
语毕，老尼古拉自顾自地走了。

Windsong hastens to follow him, but Professor Ivanov calls out to her.
正当北方哨歌准备灰溜溜地跟上去时，伊万诺夫教授却喊道。

Professor Ivanov: Comrade Ekaterina?
伊万诺夫教授：瓦莲京娜同志?

Windsong: Yes, Professor?
北方哨歌：是！教授，有什么事?

She turns back to face him.
北方哨歌回头望去。

The professor stands beneath a huge portrait on the wall. It is the portrait of the founding father of their discipline, Tristan Lisov.
教授身后的墙壁闯入了她的视野，墙上挂着特里斯坦·莱索夫——理线学奠基人——的画像。

In the portrait, Lisov casts a calm and confident gaze to the left, like he can already see the promise of the future.
在画像中，特里斯坦·莱索夫目光坚毅地望着左上方，仿佛那里有绝对光明的未来。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: "The 21st century belongs to the study of ley lines!"
北方哨歌：“21 世纪，将会是理线学的世纪！”……

The motto is placed right beneath his portrait.
莱索夫的画像下面贴着这样一句振奋人心的话。

It's the first thing anyone sees when they enter the building.
它迎接着每位研究所里心怀梦想的理线师。

Professor Ivanov: Welcome to the new world. Our new world.
伊万诺夫教授：欢迎来到新世界。

Windsong: ...!
北方哨歌：……！

Windsong: Thank you, sir.
北方哨歌：谢谢。

Snapping back to the moment, Windsong's eyes turn to her professor again.
目光重新落回了教授身上。

Windsong: Our new world. Finally, I can make a difference. Broaden our understanding of ley lines. Lead us into a new future.
北方哨歌：就像是得到了守门人的认可，真理的殿堂终于敞开，我成为了这里的一份子……

She gives a solemn nod.
北方哨歌郑重地点了点头。

She swiftly turns around and rushes to catch up with Old Nik.
跟上了早已在远处的老尼古拉的脚步。

8#1
8#1

寄生蜂群
Parasites CH18603-03

Windsong: The time is ... 8:29. Ekaterina. Clocked in.
北方哨歌：现在是……8 点 29 分，瓦莲京娜，到达实验室。

Windsong tosses the pen aside. It dangles from the string attaching it to the sign-in board.
北方哨歌扔下手中的笔，笔的末端被绑到了签到板上，因此它不会掉到地上去，也不会莫名其妙地丢掉。

Windsong: Has it only been three months? It feels like twice as long.
北方哨歌：在研究所工作的时间竟才过了三个月吗？我还以为已经过了半年……

Windsong: *yawn* We're moving onto stage 3 today.
北方哨歌：呵——啊……今天该进行第三阶段的实验了……

She yawns deeply.
北方哨歌深深地打了个呵欠，但她不能睡。

Old Nikola: ...
老尼古拉：……

Windsong: *yawning*
北方哨歌：呵——呵——啊……

She has no time to rest, but the drowsiness is only getting stronger.
哈欠和困倦就像雪球一般越滚越大。

Windsong: Ah! Ah! My jaw! Oh. I thought I dislocated it for a second.
北方哨歌：天呐，我的下巴！哦……它还好，它没有脱臼。

Old Nikola: ...
老尼古拉：……

Old Nikola: Ahem!
老尼古拉：呵——咳！

He pinches the bridge of his nose in irritation.
老尼古拉用指尖揉了揉鼻根和眼眶的交界处。

Old Nikola: Comrade Ekaterina! Over here!
老尼古拉：瓦莲京娜同志！你过来一下！

Windsong: Yes!
北方哨歌：是！

Old Nikola aligns the papers on the desk and sets them aside.
老尼古拉将手中的报告摞整齐，放在了桌子上。

Old Nikola: I've read your paper. Not too bad for a first draft. I've made a few notes that might be helpful to you.
老尼古拉：批改都在上面了，没什么大问题，作为第一份理线学论文来说，你做得还算合格。

Old Nikola: When did you leave the lab last night?
老尼古拉：昨晚几点离开实验室的?

Windsong: A little after 2 a.m., Comrade Nikola. I made sure to clock out before I left.
北方哨歌：两点多，尼古拉同志，我记在了实验室的签到册上。

Old Nikola: Then, when can I see that lab report?
老尼古拉：那么实验报告什么时候能给我?

Windsong: Before the end of today.
北方哨歌：今天。

Old Nikola: Today? I don't think so. Your schedule's packed.
老尼古拉：今天？我看今天你有别的事要做。

Windsong: Is it? What am I going to do?
北方哨歌：什么事情?

Old Nikola: Pack your things.
老尼古拉：比如收拾行李。

Windsong: ...?
北方哨歌：……?

Windsong: Why, Old Nik? I thought you liked my paper! You can't just flip the switch and start hating me because I yawned a few times—or can you?
北方哨歌：何至于，老尼古拉！我的论文不是没什么大问题吗？还是说因为我在您面前打了两个大呵欠，您就要赶我走?

Old Nikola: What did you just call me?
老尼古拉：你叫我什么?

Windsong: Ahem. Sorry, sir.
北方哨歌：……咳，对不起。

Old Nikola: Why do you think there's no one in the lab at this hour?
老尼古拉：现在这个时间，实验室里还没有人，你认为是什么原因?

Windsong: Well ...
北方哨歌：因为……

Windsong: Oh!
北方哨歌：哦——

The researchers are all crowded in front of the notice board. The project bid results have been released.
研究员们正齐齐挤在大厅的公告栏前，因为今天是发布项目招标结果的日子。

Windsong: I completely forgot!
北方哨歌：我竟然把这件事给忘记了。

Old Nikola: Go take a look. You did well on that proposal. They'd be smart to have you on their list. And if they don't, you still have your spot on the Arctic expedition team.
老尼古拉：去看看吧。你的课题应该可以通过审查的，就算没有，北境科考队里也留着你的位置。

Old Nikola: Have a look at mine for me, too. If you're not too busy celebrating any good news, that is.
老尼古拉：记得也看一下我的课题。

Windsong: Sure thing.
北方哨歌：好的。

The board is layered with papers detailing old announcements. The latest one is pinned on top, listing the projects that have been granted national funding.
最新的公示结果贴在了层层叠叠的往期公示的上面，昭示着有哪些项目获得了来自国家层面的资金援助。

Windsong: Please, I have to get through. Sorry.
北方哨歌：抱歉，请让一下。

She can't see past the crowd in any direction.
人群死死地遮挡住了公告栏。

Yelena: Is that you, Comrade Ekaterina? Want a sip? It's vodka. You must've been put through a lot working with Old Nik.
叶莲娜：您还好吗，瓦莲京娜同志，需不需要来一口伏特加？您在老尼古拉手下过得太辛苦了。

Windsong: I'm okay. Ouch! That's my foot!
北方哨歌：我没事……哦！请别踩我。

Assistant Researcher I: Sorry, comrade.
助理研究员 I：抱歉，同志。

The crowd pushes her around. She holds onto Yelena's sleeve to keep herself from falling.
北方哨歌被人群推挤着，个子稍高的叶莲娜在尽力护她的周全。

Yelena: We're packed tighter than a can of sardines here. We shouldn't have come so early. Alright, let me see. Where's our Ekaterina's hamster project?
叶莲娜：现在大家都挤在这里，为什么不过一会再来看呢。哈哈哈，来吧，我帮您找找，看看我们小仓鼠的项目通过了没有。

Windsong: Gerbils, Comrade Yelena. They're gerbils, not hamsters.
北方哨歌：那不是仓鼠，叶莲娜同志，我现在研究的是沙鼠。

Yelena: Yeah, yeah, I hear you. Gerbils, gerbils ... I don't see any gerbils here. Oh, there's your name. You're going to Taryga?!
叶莲娜：嗯……沙鼠，沙鼠……没有找到沙鼠的项目，但是我看见了瓦莲京娜同志的……您要去特利迦?!

More people push in, squeezing them out of the crowd. Windsong notices that most of the people who are already leaving have satisfied smiles on their faces. Clearly, they are content with the outcome.
急于确认自己的项目是否得到资金支持的研究员们将二人从公告栏前挤了出去，大部分离开的人都心满意足，看来得到了不错的答案。

Yelena: You can't be serious, Comrade Ekaterina. Maybe you got the destination wrong after staying up late all week?
叶莲娜：瓦莲京娜同志，您疯了吗？一整周的通宵是不是让您记错目的地了？

Yelena: All the effort you put into that bid document just to be assigned to Taryga, the place where even vultures struggle to survive!
叶莲娜：您是说……您这么费心费力写的项目标书，居然是为了去特利迦那个狗熊都下不了崽的鬼地方?!

Windsong: Yes, Comrade Yelena. I've read some interesting accounts about that place. It's calling out for exploration.
北方哨歌：是的，叶莲娜同志，前两天我找资料的时候在那里看到了很有趣的记录，我猜想，那里一定有一片富饶的处女地!

Yelena: So you'll ride a goat across the mountains to become a shaman queen in the wilderness? Oh, my Ekaterina.
叶莲娜：您准备骑着山羊翻过那些山，然后在您发现的处女地里成为特利迦女王吗？我的瓦莲京娜。

Yelena dramatically buries her face in her hands, unable to fathom the hardship.
叶莲娜痛苦地用手掩住了脸庞。

Windsong: Don't worry about me. Were you selected too?
北方哨歌：好了好了，说说你吧，你的项目肯定也通过了，对吗?

Yelena: Yes, I'm going to Frankfurt.
叶莲娜：是的，我要前往法兰克福。

Windsong: Definitely an upgrade from Taryga.
北方哨歌：那可真是个不错的地方。

Windsong: What's happening over there?
北方哨歌：那边发生了什么了?

Yelena: Ah, it's Alexei and the boys. Seems like they won the bid, too.
叶莲娜：是阿列克谢他们，看来他们的项目也获得了资金的支持。

Windsong: Alexei? I thought he was working for—
北方哨歌：阿列克谢？他不是……

Yelena: Oh, Ekaterina, you really should come to the pub with us more often! You've missed out on everything!
叶莲娜：哦……多和我们下下酒馆吧，我的瓦莲京娜。

Yelena: He left the Kolaria Superdeep Borehole Project a while ago. Now he's his own boss, running a project with his own people.
叶莲娜：阿列克谢他早就离开“科拉利亚超深钻井计划”了，现在他自己组建了一个小组，还当上了组长。

Yelena: What's it called? Something like "A Ley-Line Perspective on Quantum Field Theory and Its Application in Energy Conversion and Transmission" ... Oof, quite the mouthful.
叶莲娜：他们这次招标的项目叫什么来着，“理线学视角下量子场理论在能源的转换与传输中的应用”……可真够复杂的。

Windsong: Quantum field theory? But we don't have an optical lab here. Where are they going to do the experiments?
北方哨歌：量子？我们研究所并没有光学实验室，他们拿什么做研究？

Yelena: Who knows. I'm sure Alexei will find a way—you know, with help from his family.
叶莲娜：谁知道呢，反正阿列克谢肯定是有办法解决的……您知道他家什么情况吧？

Yelena: His old man wouldn't bat an eye at the bill required to build a new lab.
叶莲娜：对他家来说，给我们研究所捐助一个实验室也就是数数钞票的事情。

Yelena: You wait and see. With his articles getting published one after another, there's no doubt that he'll be made director of some department soon.
叶莲娜：按照他出论文的速度，看着吧，再过三个月说不定就能评个主任级别的职务了。

Yelena: And there's no other discipline that gets as much love from the journal editors as ours does.
叶莲娜：除了“理线学”的论文，没有哪个学科能发期刊发得这么顺利。

Yelena: People put a lot of faith in ley lines, you see.
叶莲娜：人人都信任理线学。

Windsong: But ...
北方哨歌：这……

Yelena: But people like Old Nik can't stand when academics cut corners, so you never would've heard any of this from him.
叶莲娜：这种事，老尼古拉是肯定不会点头的，所以您不知道也正常。

Windsong: I see your point, Comrade Yelena.
北方哨歌：哦……你说得对，叶莲娜同志……

Yelena: I know what you're trying to say—that passion from the populace can sometimes be a threat to scientific rigor. But it also gives us an edge, don't you think?
叶莲娜：我知道您在想什么，瓦莲京娜同志，但是您想想，这也有好处不是吗？

Yelena: Do you remember that village we visited? The chief must be a Varangian. Stubborn guy.
叶莲娜：您还记得之前我们去的那个村子吗？我猜那个村长一定是个纯血瓦良格人。

Yelena: But even he granted us permission to explore near their village when we said we were ley hunters.
叶莲娜：但就算是这么固执的人，一听到“理线学”，也同意我们在他的家乡中勘探了。

Windsong: Yes, but that was because he wanted us to see if there were gold mines or oil beneath their village.
北方哨歌：但他是建立在想要无穷无尽的黄金和石油的基础上……

Yelena: Yes, my dear Ekaterina, and we'd probably still be enjoying the saunas in their banya if you hadn't broken the truth to him so quickly!
叶莲娜：是的，我的瓦莲京娜，要不是您去跟村长讲了实话，我们说不定还能在他们的巴尼亚里蒸蒸桑拿！

Yelena: But let's not argue over the past. In the end, we successfully completed the task and gathered enough materials for the report, didn't we?
叶莲娜：别想这些不愉快的了，好吗？想想我们最后的勘测报告吧。

Yelena: It's true the chief didn't get the news he wanted, but at least we secured our spots in the institute. And it was all thanks to that report.
叶莲娜：那份报告虽然没能给那个村子变出一个聚宝盆，但它让我们顺利留在研究所了。

She recalls the chief's furious expression and piercing gaze. He had looked at them as if they were a pair of frauds. The memory sends shivers down her spine.
回想起离开时村长用看骗子的眼神狠狠地盯着他们每个人时的画面，北方哨歌的心情更沉一分。

Windsong: Well, what are you going to do in Frankfurt, then?
北方哨歌：那你呢，你去法兰克福做什么？

Yelena: There's a new project on hydrothermal mineral deposits. And I've had enough of the cold up here in the north. It's time to go somewhere warmer for a change.
叶莲娜：是一个有关于水热矿化的项目……最近实在是太冷了，我觉得我的骨髓里都是冰碴子，我想去一个不那么冷的地方。

Windsong: Sounds good. I heard they have some nice hot springs there. Maybe you can give them a try.
北方哨歌：那完成项目之后，你还能在那里泡泡温泉——我听说，法兰克福的温泉是很养人的。

Yelena gives a joyful smile.
叶莲娜微笑了起来。

Yelena: You always give the best advice, Ekaterina. I'll be sure to keep an eye out for any gifts. Maybe I can bring you something back.
叶莲娜：谢谢您的建议，我的瓦莲京娜，我会给您带点小礼物回来的。

Windsong: Sausages or some apple wine would be perfect. How about you? Would you like a bear cub from the north?
北方哨歌：香肠，或者苹果酒，你可以直接把它们喂给我带回来的棕熊。

Yelena: Hahaha, you can spare me that one! Take care. We won't be seeing each other much for a while.
叶莲娜：看来我们有一阵时间不能相见了。

They lightly touch cheeks, and Windsong watches Yelena stride away.
叶莲娜友好地贴了贴北方哨歌的脸，随后她便离开了。

She realizes that the hallway has become quiet again.
停止了寒暄后，北方哨歌突然意识到周遭已经变得安静了许多。

Having checked their results, the crowd has long gone.
大多数人已经确认完了自己的项目，现在的公告栏前空无一人。

But Windsong has one more thing to check.
北方哨歌还没能看到老尼古拉的项目，所以她走上前去。

She doesn't see Old Nik's name on the first page, so she flips to the next, and then the next, until she finally finds his project on the last sheet. Then she notices the yellowing papers beneath.
老尼古拉的项目在这一批的最后一张，北方哨歌轻轻地翻开了刚贴好的公示，露出了下面已经开始泛黄的纸张。

Windsong: "Sustainable Agriculture in Developing Countries: A Ley Line Analysis," "A Ley Line Perspective on Efficiency in Heavy Industry and Optimization" ...
北方哨歌：“理线学指导下发展中国家的可持续农业实践”，“理线学视角下重工业的能效管理与优化策略”……

Windsong: "Prospect and Development," "Theory and Applications" ...
北方哨歌：“理线学的前景与发展”，“理线学的原理与应用”……

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: This is the work of every ley hunter in this institution.
北方哨歌：每一个项目，都会公示在这里……

She runs her fingers along the pages, finally coming to a stop on the oldest one.
北方哨歌的指尖滑向最后一张公示文件。

Windsong: Here lies the history of ley lines.
北方哨歌：这里……陈列着理线学的历史。

She mutters to herself.
北方哨歌喃喃自语道。

Windsong: So many people have tried so many things—and all at the same time—simultaneously exploring the possibilities of applying ley lines to all kinds of disciplines.
北方哨歌：关于理线学的研究，方向还真是千奇百怪。看来理线师们一直在探索理线学的应用面到底有多广。

Windsong: But, why? Most of these attempts seem to have only scratched the surface.
北方哨歌：但是，却没有更深入的……?

She goes through them all again.
她一层一层地翻着。

Windsong: Many of them were given up when the researchers encountered the first few obstacles. It's like they never even intended to dig deeper into the subject.
北方哨歌：大多数项目因为其实验性质已经宣告失败，他们对理线学的尝试更像是浅尝辄止。

Windsong: Two ... Maybe three? There are no more than three topics within the same area of research.
北方哨歌：两个……三个？相同领域下的项目没有超过三个。

Windsong: Maybe they'll come back to them when they have more data. It's still a young subject, after all.
北方哨歌：……也可以理解，毕竟理线学诞生的时间并不长，也许更深层的研究现在仍在进行数据验证。

Windsong: But ...
北方哨歌：但……

Windsong: So much talent and brainpower has been diverted to all these different areas.
北方哨歌：理线师们就像平地的一滩水，毫无目的地向四面八方流去……

Windsong: If we'd just worked together more, we'd probably have a wealth of knowledge by now.
北方哨歌：拢都拢不起来。

Windsong: No wonder Old Nik doesn't like it here.
北方哨歌：怪不得老尼古拉不喜欢这里。

8#1
8#1

兔与龟
Tortoise and the Hare CH18603-04

Mountain Cabin, Taryga
特利迦·山中小木屋

The cold weather in Taryga clears all other thoughts from Windsong's mind, and the happenings of the research institute seem distant amid the snowy mountains.
寒冷的气候让北方哨歌更加关心毛毯的厚度，在研究所发生的那些不愉快的事也被层层落雪埋进了泥土里。

It's already the end of her second month here.
转眼之间，北方哨歌已经在特利迦停留了将近两个月的时间。

Windsong: *Today marks the 32nd day of our exploration.*

A new mine has been found at the pass of the mountain known by the locals as "Bear Mountain."
北方哨歌：经过为期 32 天的勘察，通过追踪该能量线——

在村民们称之为“大熊山”的山隘处发现了一处新的矿藏。

Windsong: Urgh. I can't stop shivering. No heating, no hot water. Taryga is cruel. I better ask the gatekeeper to bring me more firewood.
北方哨歌：好冷。这就是特利迦，没有电暖气，没有热水管……一会该让门房再给我添点柴火。

She pulls the blanket tighter around her shoulders.
北方哨歌裹紧了披在身上的毛毯。

Windsong: *Aside from that ...*
北方哨歌：此外……

She dips her pen in the ink bottle.
北方哨歌沾沾墨水。

Windsong: *We also found a group of critters, which the locals refer to as "shamama," during our mining.*
北方哨歌：开采矿脉期间，在矿脉深处发现一窝当地人称作“萨玛玛”的魔精。

Windsong: *After thoroughly examining their feathers and excrement and observing their habits and behaviors over a period of time,*

I believe these shamamas are a variant of the long-extinct critters, the "domovoy."
北方哨歌：在收集其落羽、粪便，确认过其生活习性后——

我认为“萨玛玛”就是消失已久的魔精“多毛沃伊”的变异种。

Windsong: *With much effort, we have successfully relocated them to a new reservation.*
北方哨歌：经过一段时间的引导，“萨玛玛”的族群已成功迁徙到了我与村民建立的保护区中。

Windsong: Thank you, Sofia. I wouldn't have been able to identify the shamamas without your help.
北方哨歌：谢谢你，索菲亚，没有你的话，我根本确认不了“萨玛玛”是什么品种。

She's writing to Sofia, a researcher who previously shared information about critters local to Taryga with her.
为了确认魔精相关的信息，北方哨歌与一名叫作“索菲亚”的人类学者建立起了书信往来。

Their correspondence is piled high on the table.
北方哨歌抬起头来，来往过的信件已经摞了厚厚一叠。

Windsong: Boy, that's already quite a stack. How many letters have we written?
北方哨歌：已经这么多了？

She pulls the letters closer to her and counts them one by one.
北方哨歌将放在书桌上的信拿了过来，清点着数目。

Windsong: Oh, there aren't a huge number; it's just that each of them is quite chunky.
北方哨歌：哦——我的记忆没出错，数量上还是这几封，只不过每封都很厚罢了。

Windsong: I totally get it, Sofia. Living in a place where the mailman only comes once a fortnight and cramming as much info into each letter as possible.
北方哨歌：是啊，她也在一个邮差十天半个月都不会来的地方，所以每次也是在信封里塞上好几张信纸。

Windsong: We've never quite managed to squeeze our theories into just one page, have we?
北方哨歌：不这么做的话，想阐述的理论压根写不完……

Today's letter, however, is concise.
但今天的信不必写那样的长篇大论。

Windsong: *I've received news that my paper has been successfully published. Can't wait to catch up with you in Yakutsk.*
北方哨歌：论文已经寄出并顺利刊登，期待与你在雅库特斯克相见。

Upon writing the last word, she sets the letter aside to let the ink dry.
北方哨歌写上了句号，结束了这封信的撰写。

Windsong: Yakutsk. Some say it's even colder than here. Oof. But Sofia and those ovinniks are there. Definitely worth a visit.
北方哨歌：雅库特斯克……那是个比特利迦还冷的地方，但索菲亚和她的“奥维尼克”在那里等着我。

Windsong: Ovinnik? Is that the name?
北方哨歌：“奥维尼克”?

Straightening up in her chair, she picks up one of the letters to check.
为了回忆起更多关于“奥维尼克”的事，北方哨歌翻看起了那摞厚厚的信。

Windsong: Hah. Funny that I've never noticed this.
北方哨歌：哈……我怎么才发现！

Windsong: "Dear Comrade Ekaterina," comma, "regarding the critters you found" ... "Dear Comrade," comma, "in response to the previous questions on ley lines" ...
北方哨歌：“瓦莲京娜同志”，逗号，“关于魔精的介绍”。“瓦莲京娜同志”，逗号，“关于理线学的疑问”。

Windsong: Not exactly the "so glad to hear from you," "take care and stay warm," "yours faithfully" type, are you, Sofia? Always straight to the point.
北方哨歌：信里连个“展信佳”、“祝顺利”之类的话都没有……

Windsong: If you wore a pair of thick glasses, you'd be a real "Professor Stoneface."
北方哨歌：她一定是一位严肃又寡言的姑娘，满脑子里只有学问。

Amused by the thought, she folds the letter and puts it in a new envelope.
北方哨歌一边饶有兴致地猜测着，一边将写好的信折好，封进一个全新的信封中。

Windsong: Leave it at the door, please! And could I also get some more firewood?
北方哨歌：请把报纸放在门口吧！顺便再添点柴火给我！

???: I have a letter for you, Comrade Ekaterina!
???：瓦莲京娜同志！你的信！

Windsong: A letter? Today?
北方哨歌：信?

Windsong: For me? From whom?
北方哨歌：谁寄给我的?

Mailman: The Ley Line Institute.
信差：理线学研究所。

Windsong: I see. Thank you.
北方哨歌：好的，辛苦您了。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: A complaint letter about me? From Frankfurt?
北方哨歌：来自法兰克福的投诉信？投诉……我?

Windsong: Frankfurt ... Yelena?
北方哨歌：法兰克福……叶莲娜?

The old notice board, the smell of ink, and the conversation about sausages and apple wine suddenly come back to her.
公告栏、油墨味、香肠与苹果酒，那段记忆渐渐从脑海里浮现了出来。

Windsong: Could this have anything to do with her?
北方哨歌：是她做了什么吗?

The letter gives no direct answer.
但信上并没有关于这部分的答案。

Mailman: Do you have anything to mail? If not, I'll leave you to your business.
信差：同志，没有事的话我就先走了。

Windsong: Ah, wait a moment, comrade!
北方哨歌：请等一下，同志。

Windsong: Is there a bus leaving for this address today? It's urgent.
北方哨歌：稍晚点的时候，你们有发往这个地址的车吗？我有急事。

Yelena and Alexei stand in the office, muttering to each other with grave expressions on their faces.
办公室中，叶莲娜正面色凝重地和阿列克谢低声交谈着。

Windsong: What on earth is going on, Comrade Yelena?!
北方哨歌：叶莲娜同志，这到底是怎么回事?!

They immediately turn toward the sound.
叶莲娜和阿列克谢停止了谈话，转向北方哨歌。

Yelena: Oh, it's you, Ekaterina! Don't worry, I have everything under control. It won't cause you any trouble.
叶莲娜：哦……我的瓦莲京娜，您回来了。别担心，我会处理好这件事的，不留痕迹地。

Windsong: Why? Why was I on your bid document? We aren't even in the same group!
北方哨歌：为什么要把我写在招标书上？我并不是你的组员!

Yelena: I was trying to secure more funding, so I listed you as a co-author of the report. I should have talked to you first. But none of us would be in trouble if he hadn't filed the complaint to get back at me!
叶莲娜：这只是为了让资金更加充裕一些，而且我也把您写进了报告的联合作者里……我是该先征求您的同意的……谁知道他居然投诉到研究所里来了!

Windsong: Who?
北方哨歌：谁?

Yelena: Some hotel owner in Frankfurt. He asked us to check if there were any gold mines beneath his hot spring.
叶莲娜：那个倒打一耙的旅馆老板，他央求我们帮他看看旅馆的温泉下有没有什么金矿。

Windsong: And did you promise him anything?
北方哨歌：你承诺他什么了？

Yelena: I ... Oh, Ekaterina ... I ... I didn't really promise him anything.
叶莲娜：哦……我的瓦莲京娜……我……我什么都没有承诺。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

She stares at Yelena in both disappointment and anger.
北方哨歌沉默地看着叶莲娜，就像最初那名村长。

Yelena: Don't give me that look. Please, Ekaterina. I said I'd handle it carefully and make sure your reputation remains intact.
叶莲娜：别这么看着我……瓦莲京娜……我说了我会处理好的，不会让您的名誉受损。

Yelena: Look, I made a mistake. I'll make it up to you. Take a look at this.
叶莲娜：这件事是我做错了，我会偿还您的，您看这个。

Yelena: It's different this time—there's really something worth studying!
叶莲娜：和法兰克福那次不一样，这次我们是真的要去研究点新东西。

Yelena: Comrade Tristan Lisov's just pointed us in a new direction—the ocean has limitless possibilities lying within it. Professor Vladmir Ivanov's also on board, and he hopes you can join us, too.
叶莲娜：特里斯坦·莱索夫同志刚指出了海洋蕴含着无限的可能，弗拉基米尔·伊万诺夫教授也会一起去的——而且他也希望您能去。

Windsong: But what's there to investigate? Oil and gas? Mapping continental shelves? They hardly make a strong research topic, and you certainly don't need so many ley hunters to research them.
北方哨歌：寻找海底石油，勘测大陆架……这有什么无限的可能？这连课题都算不上，也用不着这么多理线师去。

Alexei: But don't you want to meet Comrade Lisov in person?
阿列克谢：难道你不想见莱索夫同志一面吗？

Alexei: You don't get to meet the experts from the Academy of Sciences every day! Make a good impression, and it might help with your future funding. You never know.
阿列克谢：我们平时可没有机会见到科学院专家级别的人物！如果能给他留下一点印象，没准以后项目资金都会更好批一些。

Yelena: He's right, Ekaterina. Let's go together, shall we? I owe you one after all this.
叶莲娜：是的，瓦莲京娜，我们一起去吧？原谅我，好吗？

Windsong: The ocean? I don't ...
北方哨歌：去海洋项目？

Yelena: It's all about seizing the right opportunity, and trust me, Ekaterina, this is it!
叶莲娜：那真的是个千载难逢的好机会，听我说，瓦莲京娜……

Windsong: No, Yelena, listen.
北方哨歌：等一下，叶莲娜……

Yelena continues to speak, but Windsong only finds her voice increasingly unbearable.
但叶莲娜还在劝慰着北方哨歌，如牛蝇般的絮语声让北方哨歌心烦意乱。

Windsong: Yelena!
北方哨歌：叶莲娜！

She throws the letter to Yelena's feet.
北方哨歌将那封信扔到了地上。

Windsong: Could you just take one moment and think this through? Is this really the right thing to do?
北方哨歌：您不觉得奇怪吗？您看看，您在说些什么呢。

Yelena exchanges a helpless look with Alexei.
叶莲娜无措地与阿列克谢对视了一眼。

Yelena: What do you want to do, then?
叶莲娜：那您想要什么呢?

Windsong opens her mouth; all of a sudden, she hesitates.
北方哨歌张开嘴，却不知道是否应该说出这句话。

Windsong: I just want to focus on my project.
北方哨歌：我只想好好做项目。

Windsong: No novel ideas and directions; no fawning over well-connected people.
北方哨歌：不用考虑其他事情，做自己该做的研究。

She looks straight into their eyes. They are wide with surprise.
北方哨歌直视着二人惊讶的面容。

Windsong: Good luck finding someone who shares your vision.
北方哨歌：……别把我牵扯进来。

Yelena: ...
叶莲娜：……

Yelena: Do you really mean that, Comrade Ekaterina?
叶莲娜：您是认真的吗，瓦莲京娜同志?

Alexei: Old Nik doesn't know any better.
阿列克谢：老尼古拉把你的脑袋都教坏了。

The silence among them becomes stifling.
沉默在三人之中膨胀。

Alexei: You can't stay in your little bubble forever. There's a lot happening out there, and you can't escape from it by wandering in the wilderness.
阿列克谢：瓦莲京娜同志，你就像是活在玻璃罩里，你压根不知道理线学的现状。也难怪，因为你永远都游离在那些荒山野岭里。

Yelena: Do you have any idea how hard it is to publish a paper these days?
叶莲娜：您知道现在发一篇由理线学主导的论文，要付出什么样的代价吗?

Alexei: You've got to earn Professor Ivanov's trust—to win him over. Then he'll bring up your name to Dean Lisov, or maybe even introduce you to him in person.
阿列克谢：首先，要讨伊万诺夫教授的喜欢，接下来，要和伊万诺夫教授一起，想办法让莱索夫院长记住你。

Alexei: Getting there requires talent, wealth, and social skills. Otherwise, who knows how long your paper will sit at the bottom of their drawer?
阿列克谢：别出心裁、身家万贯，或者……七窍玲珑，不然……你知道一篇论文最长能卡多久吗?

Alexei: Well, maybe not that long. Someone else will probably beat you to publishing your idea.
阿列克谢：可能也不会很久，只要有别人先比你发出来。

Windsong: Old Nik never warned me about any of this.
北方哨歌：……我从没听老尼古拉说过这些。

Yelena: That's why Old Nik is always Old Nik, not Professor Nikola or Director Nikola.
叶莲娜：所以老尼古拉永远只能是老尼古拉，而不是什么尼古拉教授，尼古拉主任。

Yelena: He's never been credited as the first author of a paper.
叶莲娜：他也永远只能做第二作者，甚至第三作者。

Windsong: No. This is a sheer violation of academic integrity.
北方哨歌：不……这……完全就是对学术的亵渎……

Yelena: Academic integrity? What's the point of valuing integrity if the subject barely exists anymore?
叶莲娜：学术？我们还能研究什么？您真的觉得理线学算一门独立的学科吗？

Yelena: We've found no new theories, theorems, or laws. We've just been verifying the existing ones, telling the world what it already knows.
叶莲娜：那些前沿理论、定理、法则，前人早都挖干净了……理线学已经不会再有新玩意蹦出来了。

Yelena: No one knows this subject better than we do. And we all know there's nothing sophisticated about it.
叶莲娜：我们该是最了解理线学的人，也该明白它压根不是什么多深奥的学问。

Yelena: At best, it's just a tool serving other subjects. You must understand that better than any of us!
叶莲娜：我们再怎么做研究，也只能挂靠在别的学科上……您该是我们之中最明白这件事的人！

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

With just a slight turn of her head, Windsong can see the notice board beside them.
只需微微侧头，便可看到那面公告栏。

She remembers those projects—the history written on the fragile yellowed papers.
那些项目涌入她的脑海。

Windsong: No. I've made up my mind. I don't want to be a part of this.
北方哨歌：总之……这个海洋项目，我是不会去的。

Windsong: And please don't add my name to any more of your lists, Comrade Yelena.
北方哨歌：以后也请你不要擅自将我的名字写在你的项目中，叶莲娜同志。

Alexei: Wait, Ekaterina. You can't just leave.
阿列克谢：等一下，请先别离开，瓦莲京娜同志。

Windsong: What is it?
北方哨歌：怎么了？

Alexei: If you insist on not participating, you have to tell the professor yourself.
阿列克谢：如果你不想参加这次的项目的话，我想，你需要去和教授当面说明。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: Fine. I'll talk to him.
北方哨歌：知道了。

"Knock-knock."
“叩叩。”

Professor Ivanov: Come in.
伊万诺夫教授： 请进。

Windsong: Sir, is it a good time?
北方哨歌： 教授，打扰了。

Professor Ivanov: I was expecting you, Ekaterina! Your paper on Taryga was truly impressive—a valuable case study indeed!
伊万诺夫教授： 瓦莲京娜同志！你来得正好，我正在看你那篇关于特利迦地区的论文，你做出了一份十分有价值的研究！

Putting the journal aside, Professor Ivanov greets her with a warm smile.
伊万诺夫教授将手中的期刊放下，笑容满面地对北方哨歌说道。

Professor Ivanov: Comrade Tristan Lisov has also read your paper. He told me he's looking forward to seeing more of your work on the upcoming project.
伊万诺夫教授： 特里斯坦·莱索夫同志也看到了你这篇论文，他跟我说，他很期待你能在海洋项目中发光发热，快请坐下吧。

Professor Ivanov: That is why you're here, is it not?
伊万诺夫教授： 来找我有什么事?

He gestures to the chair across the table, then pours some tea into the cup in front of it.
北方哨歌落座在伊万诺夫教授对面，教授拎起保温瓶，向北方哨歌面前的玻璃杯里缓缓注满了热水。

Windsong: Yes, sir. I appreciate your and Comrade Lisov's recognition of my work, but ...
北方哨歌： 弗拉基米尔·伊万诺夫教授，我也是来找您说这件事的，很感谢特里斯坦·莱索夫同志的赏识，但是这次的项目……

Windsong: I won't be joining you in this new project.
北方哨歌： 我想我参加不了了。

Professor Ivanov: Why? It's a good opportunity.
伊万诺夫教授： 为什么？这是个很难得的机会。

He pauses, still holding the teapot in his hands.
伊万诺夫教授的手停下了。

Windsong: I understand that, but I've decided on my next topic.
北方哨歌： 很抱歉，但我已经决定启程前往另一个地方。

She hands him a crumpled envelope. The professor pulls out a thick stack of papers from it.
北方哨歌将有些破损的信封递了过去，教授从中拿出了一摞叠得厚厚的信纸。

Professor Ivanov: What is this?
伊万诺夫教授： 这是什么?

He takes the glasses from his pocket, puts them on, and peers at the letter.
伊万诺夫教授将领口别着的眼镜戴到鼻梁之上，将信举远，然而眉毛还是因为眼睛失焦而皱紧起来。

His eyebrows knit together as he reads, his eyes scanning from left to right. After a moment, he puts the letter down.
他的眼睛由左至右地滑动，没掠过几行便停住了。

Professor Ivanov: "Ovinnik"?
伊万诺夫教授： “奥维尼克”?

Windsong: Yes, sir.
北方哨歌： 是的，教授。

He takes on a somber countenance.
教授的面色阴沉了下来。

Professor Ivanov: Comrade Ekaterina, I trust you to be a person of reason. There's simply no other project more promising than the Ocean Project.
伊万诺夫教授： 瓦莲京娜同志，我想你该知道，这个项目是轰动整个理线学的大项目。

Professor Ivanov: It's led by the founding father of our subject. Anyone who writes a paper under him will undoubtedly take a significant step up the academic ladder.
伊万诺夫教授： 它由创始人发起，如果谁能在这个项目里做成一番研究，那他在学派里的地位也会更加稳固。

Windsong: Yes, I have no doubt about that.
北方哨歌： 是的，我明白。

Professor Ivanov: Then why would you give up such a valuable opportunity and choose to work in the north with some nobody instead?
伊万诺夫教授： 那你出于什么想法，要舍弃这么有价值的项目，而跑去一个极寒之地，跟一个无名之辈合作呢?

Windsong: Valuable ...
北方哨歌： 有价值……

Windsong: Yakutsk has its value too, sir.
北方哨歌： 难道雅库特斯克的项目就没有价值了吗?

Professor Ivanov: Yes, an interdisciplinary study on critter ecology. That could be interesting, but ...
伊万诺夫教授： ……理线学和魔精生态学的结合……确实是一次很有意思的尝试，但……

Professor Ivanov: What will that project give you?
伊万诺夫教授： 你能从那个项目里获得什么呢?

Professor Ivanov: You're on the upswing of your career thanks to your paper on Taryga. It's the perfect time to build connections in academia.
伊万诺夫教授： 你正因为特利迦地区的课题获得了不小的关注，更应该一鼓作气，结识更多能够帮助你的人。

Professor Ivanov: But what you have here doesn't look optimistic to me. You're a smart girl, Ekaterina. Act like one.
伊万诺夫教授： 这个项目的未来太渺茫了，你应该更聪明些的，瓦莲京娜同志。

Windsong: Connections? Is that what this project is for? Do you genuinely believe it's good for my career, or are you just trying to keep everyone in line?
北方哨歌： 这就是海洋项目的价值？这是对我来说的有价值，还是对学派来说的有价值?

For a moment, the professor seems puzzled.
伊万诺夫教授愣了一下。

Professor Ivanov: Comrade Ekaterina, if you really want to advance in this field ...
伊万诺夫教授： 瓦莲京娜同志，我这是出于对你未来发展的考虑……

Professor Ivanov: ... you'll find yourself at a disadvantage if you haven't participated in any projects primarily focused on ley lines.
伊万诺夫教授： 如果一直没有参与一项由理线学主导的项目的话，这对你未来的发展是很不利的。

Professor Ivanov: You know as well as I do that there hasn't been a ley line project as significant as this one since 1982.
伊万诺夫教授： 我想你应该知道，从 1982 年以后，理线学已经好几年都没有像“海洋项目”这样的大项目了。

Professor Ivanov: If this project succeeds, the credibility of the study of ley lines will skyrocket, as will the recognition of the researchers who have contributed to it.
伊万诺夫教授：这个项目的成功，将会使理线学的地位再上一层，参与这个项目的理线师们也会获得荣誉。

Windsong: With all due respect, sir, all I see is a group of people who share the same passion for meeting Comrade Lisov. Credibility doesn't seem to interest them all that much.
北方哨歌：我看到的是，人人都为结识特里斯坦·莱索夫同志而去，为了以后能更轻易地获得资金支持而去。

Windsong: I don't see any diligence here, just a thirst for fame.
北方哨歌：我在这里看不到学术，只看到了名声。

Windsong: Your valuations are all wrong, Professor.
北方哨歌：您对价值的定义太狭隘了，教授。

The professor simply shrugs at her sharp comments.
教授被耿直的研究员噎得摊了摊手。

Professor Ivanov: To tell the truth, I felt the same way when I was a young researcher myself, Comrade Ekaterina.
伊万诺夫教授：我刚入行的时候也有像你这样的困惑，瓦莲京娜同志……

Professor Ivanov: I still remember my first meeting with Comrade Lisov. My mentor gave me a fancy foreign magazine to bring along as a gift. I was terrified. It wasn't easy to get one of those back then, and I could tell it was expensive.
伊万诺夫教授：我第一次准备见莱索夫同志的时候，我的导师让我送给莱索夫同志一本内容花哨但来之不易的外国杂志，当时可真把我吓坏了。

Professor Ivanov: But Comrade Lisov was very kind to me. We talked like old friends. He appreciated the magazine and introduced me to many other researchers in the following years.
伊万诺夫教授：但莱索夫同志待我很亲切，他就像是其他接受了我好意的朋友那样与我相处，还将我引荐给了别人。

Professor Ivanov: It's a much faster way to find your footing in this circle than publishing papers year after year.
伊万诺夫教授：这可比你出十份论文都有效啊，瓦莲京娜同志……

Professor Ivanov: You have to understand that if he agrees to endorse your research and introduce you to his connections, you'll effectively have his reputation added to yours.
伊万诺夫教授：你要知道，当他向别人引荐你的时候，你的份量就不止是你的研究成果了。

Professor Ivanov: People will hold you in higher regard because of it.
伊万诺夫教授：你的身后还站着莱索夫同志，人们会将你们视为一体，会把对莱索夫同志的尊重也匀一些给你。

Professor Ivanov: You'll be able to research whatever topic you like, and people will come to you for collaboration instead of you groveling to them for a job. Don't overthink it.
伊万诺夫教授：有了这份保证，别人谈不下来的合作，也许看在莱索夫的面子上，他们就会跟你合作——你的学术之路只会更顺畅。

Professor Ivanov: It's simply a social obligation. No different from greeting your neighbors when you move to a new community.
伊万诺夫教授：这只是人跟人之间交际的基本呀，就像你刚搬去新家时会拜访你的邻居。

Professor Ivanov: Don't let emotions blind you, Comrade Ekaterina. Trust me now, and you'll see its rationale in the years to come.
伊万诺夫教授：别为它感到困扰，瓦莲京娜同志，现在先听我的去做，你最终会明白的。

Professor Ivanov: It's wisest to leave this project of yours be.
伊万诺夫教授： 所以，这次的项目……

He folds up the letter, puts it back into the envelope, and goes to toss it in the paper bin.
伊万诺夫教授简单地将信折起来，塞回了信封里，准备把它扔进垃圾箱。

Windsong: No.
北方哨歌： 不。

She snatches the envelope from his hand.
北方哨歌将它从伊万诺夫教授的手里夺了回来。

Windsong: Sorry, sir. It's not just an invitation letter. My experiment data's in there, too.
北方哨歌： 它并非只是一封邀请信，上面还记录着我的实验数据。

Professor Ivanov: Will you join us, then?
伊万诺夫教授： 那这次的项目……

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌： ……

The look on her face answers his question.
她未发一言，但她脸上的表情令教授了然。

Professor Ivanov: *sigh* You still don't understand.
伊万诺夫教授： 唉……你什么都没听进去。

Windsong: The sea breeze may be refreshing, Professor Ivanov, but only the northern mountain wind can cool this hothead.
北方哨歌： 伊万诺夫教授……海风腥得闻起来像渔夫口袋里的卢布。我想，我得让山风吹吹我过热的头脑了。

He sighs, looking down at his empty hands. He places them on the desk in resignation.
伊万诺夫教授看着空空的手，又抬头看看北方哨歌，无奈地把手放回到了桌子上。

Professor Ivanov: You have ambition. That's good.
伊万诺夫教授： 你有想做的事情，这很好。

Professor Ivanov: If I had a goal as clear as yours in my 20s, I wouldn't have listened to a word anyone said either.
伊万诺夫教授： 如果我 20 岁左右的年纪时有你这么明确的想法，兴许我也会像一匹烈马一样让人拗不住缰绳。

Professor Ivanov: And now I'm much too old to pursue any ambitions.
伊万诺夫教授： 很遗憾，我已经不是 20 岁的年纪了，烈马也太过容易受伤。

Professor Ivanov: Off you go, Ekaterina. You are still young and free.
伊万诺夫教授： 你去吧，瓦莲京娜，你还很自由。

He gestures toward the door.
伊万诺夫教授伸手做了“请”的姿势。

Windsong: Thank you, Professor.
北方哨歌： 那我先回去了，教授。

Too disappointed to say anything else, he just nods in response.
伊万诺夫教授没有说话，只是点了点头。

8#1
8#1

学者于雪海
The Researcher in Snow CH18603-05

Snowfield, Yakutsk
雅库特斯克·雪原

It's an ordinary morning in Lesnaya Forest, located in the coldest part of Yakutsk.
莱斯纳亚森林，雅库特斯克的极寒之地。

A branch from a nearby tree breaks under the weight of the snow, sending a cascade of glistening flakes to the ground.
积雪将羸弱的枝干压断，雪粒在阳光下闪烁着微弱的光芒。

A snowy owl turns its head, its large round eyes fixed on the figures in the snow.
雪鸮在松树上怪异地转着脑袋，它的目光紧紧盯着雪地上脚印尽头的两名学者。

Windsong: Sofia!
北方哨歌：索菲亚——

Sofia: Shh!
索菲亚：嘘！

Sofia: You've found them.
索菲亚：你找到它们了……

Windsong: The number of ovinniks in the area has reached the minimum viable population size you calculated.
北方哨歌：这个“奥维尼克”族群的生物数量已经符合了你估算的最小生存种群数量。

Sofia: That was just a rough calculation. We didn't have enough data about them, so I used the data of a similar species. We'll need more information to run a more accurate calculation.
索菲亚：但那个模型并不准确……我套用的是相近种族的模型，我还需要收集数据，进行更准确的计算。

Windsong: It's already October. It's minus 30 degrees right now.
北方哨歌：已经 10 月了，现在外面的气温能达到零下 30 度。

Sofia: *sigh*
索菲亚：唉……

Sofia blinks, her eyelashes coated with white frost.
索菲亚眨了眨霜白的睫毛。

Sofia: Even if you can make a fire through arcane skills to keep us warm, all the roads are still blocked.
索菲亚：就算找个能生火的神秘学家，也没办法解决大雪封山的问题。

As she speaks, her eyes are fixed on the ovinniks playing in the snow.
索菲亚的眼神紧紧地盯着在雪地中打滚的两三只“奥维尼克”。

Windsong: I think they'll survive until May.
北方哨歌：我想，它们能顺利活到明年 5 月。

Sofia: How long have we been here?
索菲亚：我们已经在这里待了多久了？

Windsong: Three months.
北方哨歌：三个月。

Sofia: And in that time we've located their nests, investigated the surroundings, and had a model established. Thanks to your help, the project is progressing much faster than expected.
索菲亚：追踪，实地勘察，到建立模型……有了你的帮助，进度比计划要快得多。

Startled by the sound, numerous birds take flight, and the ovinniks scramble back to their cave.
林中的飞鸟惊起，“奥维尼克”也被声响吓得躲回了洞里。

Windsong: Who's sawing wood in this weather?
北方哨歌：怎么会有人在这种天气里伐木。

Sofia: The local sawmill, of course.
索菲亚：是锯木厂。

Windsong: Umm. Oh!
北方哨歌：哦……哦……

Having suddenly thought of a new idea, Windsong starts scribbling on her map.
北方哨歌：北方哨歌像是想到了什么，连忙在地图上写写画画起来。

The forest falls into silence again.
待扑棱声飞远，森林又陷入了沉寂。

But the silence comes too suddenly; they are immediately alert.
但这种沉寂却唤起了二人的警惕。

Not far from them, behind a pile of snow-covered branches, the head of a white wolf emerges.
在不远处，积雪覆盖的断木堆上，一只白狼探出了头。

Windsong: Sofia, look.
北方哨歌：索菲亚，快瞧。

Sofia: Stay low.
索菲亚：蹲下。

The white wolf leaps over the wood pile. It is clearly starving. Each rib is visible beneath its fur.
白狼灵巧地从断木堆上跃下，从它流线型的运动轨迹中能望见它瘦骨嶙峋。

The White Wolf: *growl*
白狼：呼——

It sniffs at the cave's opening, its tail gently brushing the ground.
它在“奥维尼克”的洞口处嗅着，低垂的狼尾扫着木枝上的白雪。

Windsong: It's looking for food.
北方哨歌：它饿了。

Sofia: It won't fit through the burrow's entrance.
索菲亚：它进不去。

They watch the white wolf in the distance, neither one daring to move.
二人在不远处看着白狼对“奥维尼克”们虎视眈眈。

The wolf continues to pace around the cave. It has caught the scent of the ovinniks within.
它仍在洞口游走，嗅着“奥维尼克”鲜活又美味的热气。

At its command, more wolves emerge through the snow.
一声令下，四周埋伏着的狼也跃至洞前。

They gather before the cave, and the white wolf starts digging.
白狼在洞前刨了起来，企图将洞口扩大至自己能钻进去的大小。

The other wolves patrol the area, apparently looking for any other entrances to the burrow.
其他狼也开始在周围游走，防止“奥维尼克”们从别的洞口逃出。

Sofia: Don't.
索菲亚：别去。

She pushes Windsong back down.
索菲亚按住了想要驱赶狼群的北方哨歌。

The white wolf has already made a hole the size of its upper body.
为首的白狼已经将大半身子都探进了洞里。

Sofia: No.
索菲亚：不行。

Once again, she places her hand on Windsong's shoulder.
索菲亚摁着想要再次起身的北方哨歌重申道。

Windsong: The wolves will get them!
北方哨歌：难道就看着它们被吃掉吗?

A sudden commotion interrupts their hushed argument, an ovinnik dashes out of the burrow and springs onto the white wolf.
一阵骚动声从地面之下传来，一只“奥维尼克”从雪堆下窜出，用尽全力撞向那只扒洞的白狼。

Ovinnik: *roar*
“奥维尼克”：嗷嗷——

The white wolf howls in rage. It dives to avoid the hit and bites the ovinnik on the shoulder. The two roll over in the snow.
白狼虽然吃痛，但狩猎本能使它直接反口咬住了那只“奥维尼克”，惯性使它们在雪地中扭打起来。

More wolves circle around, pushing and nipping at the ovinnik. Soon enough, it is dripping with blood.
狼群围了上去，“奥维尼克”很快伤痕累累。

Windsong: We can't just stay back and watch this happen!
北方哨歌：我管不了这么多了!

Before Sofia can react, Windsong jumps up and charges toward the wolf pack.
北方哨歌冲出二人隐藏着的雪垛。

Windsong: Природа это числа и черты.
北方哨歌：Природа это числа и черты.

Sofia: You're not helping, you know.
索菲亚：你这是一种溺爱。

Sofia has also rushed over.
索菲亚从雪垛后赶了过来。

She walks straight past Windsong, kneels before the wounded ovinnik, and checks on its injuries.
她越过北方哨歌，轻轻蹲下，查看着那只“奥维尼克”的伤势。

Windsong: I didn't harm any of the wolves.
北方哨歌：只是制止了一场打架而已。

The worried look on Sofia's face makes her a little uneasy.
北方哨歌看着索菲亚紧张的神情，不屑地撇撇嘴。

Sofia: We should head back. We really shouldn't leave any human scent here.
索菲亚：我们回去吧，不要让这里染上太多人类的气息。

???: Coo-coo?
???：咕咕?

Windsong: ...?
北方哨歌：……?

They follow the gentle cooing to the burrow. A fluffy head pops out from the hole dug by the white wolf.
循着声音找去，被白狼扒得一片狼藉的洞里，探出了一个毛茸茸的脑袋。

Windsong: Is that a cub?
北方哨歌：一只……小“奥维尼克”?!

Ovinnik Cub: Coo?
“奥维尼克”幼崽：咕?

Enraptured, Windsong turns to Sofia, only to find tears in her eyes.
北方哨歌刚想向索菲亚分享这则喜讯，扭头便看到了因惊喜而眼眶含泪的索菲亚。

Sofia: Stop here.
索菲亚：别上前。

She catches Windsong's coat, stopping her from moving any further.
索菲亚扯住北方哨歌的大氅。

Sofia: We can't go any closer. We mustn't cross the line.
索菲亚：我们不能跨过那条界限，快回去吧。

Frightened by her gaze, the cub quickly dives back into the burrow and vanishes from their sight.
索菲亚的目光紧紧地凝视着那只小“奥维尼克”，小家伙被她盯得急忙钻回自己的巢穴。

Windsong: Shall we go?
北方哨歌：要走吗?

Sofia: Mm-hm.
索菲亚：嗯。

She nods, casting one last glance at the burrow.
索菲亚点点头，再次看了那个洞穴一眼。

Sofia: Let's go home.
索菲亚：快回去吧。

Forest Cabin, Yakutsk
雅库特斯克·林中小屋

The cabin is warm and quiet. Only the crackling of the fire and the sound of Windsong's scribbling fill the air.
柴火燃烧的噼啪声和北方哨歌画图的沙沙声交织在一起。

There is also the occasional sound of Sofia flipping through papers.
偶尔，还会响起纸张翻动的声音，不过声音的来源是索菲亚。

Windsong: Sofia, do we have any bear grease left? My fingers are horribly itchy.
北方哨歌：索菲亚？给我拿点熊脂，手指实在痒得不行。

Still caught up in the excitement of learning about the cub, she draws a tiny ovinnik on the map right next to where they found it.
北方哨歌仍沉浸在新生命诞生的喜悦中，她在发现幼崽的地方画了一只小小的“奥维尼克”。

Sofia puts down the papers and fetches her a jar of white salve.
索菲亚放下手中厚厚一叠的报纸，将一罐白色的膏状物递给了北方哨歌。

Sofia: Don't you arcanists have some kind of magic ointment? You know, ones that heal frostbite and such within seconds?
索菲亚：你们神秘学家没有更好的药了吗？有没有那种一抹就能把冻疮治好的药？

Windsong: Hm, probably, but I don't know much about them, to be honest. Sometimes, human medicines are more effective.
北方哨歌：嗯……可能会有吧，可惜我没了解过。而且，有时候人类的东西确实更好用一些。

Sofia: Can't ley lines make frostbite disappear?
索菲亚：理线学不能帮你消除冻疮吗？

Windsong: No. They can't change a fact.
北方哨歌：不能。它只能改变表象。

Sofia: Then you really shouldn't have taken your gloves off out there.
索菲亚：在外面的时候你就不该把手套摘下来的。

She takes some grease from the jar and starts slathering it on the back of Windsong's frostbitten hands.
索菲亚拿过熊脂，帮北方哨歌涂起了另一只手背上的冻疮。

Windsong: Haha. Still trying to master the art of sketching with my gloves on. And let's face it, if we hadn't written down all the information on the spot, we'd still be clueless about their migration patterns.
北方哨歌：戴着手套的时候不方便握笔。你看，如果没有这些即时的记录，我们不会这么快就摸清“奥维尼克”迁徙的路线。

She pushes a sketch over to Sofia.
北方哨歌将图纸挪到了索菲亚的面前。

Windsong: Here. This is the latest illustration depicting the ley energy of this group of ovinniks.
北方哨歌：这是现在代表这群“奥维尼克”的能量线图纸。

She takes out another piece of paper.
北方哨歌从下面拿出另一张已经画好的图纸。

Windsong: And this is the graph we drew three months ago.
北方哨歌：而这张图是我们刚来的时候这群“奥维尼克”的能量线。

Windsong: As you can see, the population's significantly increased, and some of them have started breeding.
北方哨歌：可以发现，这群“奥维尼克”的种群数量已经有了很显著的提高，而且我们也成功使这个族群诞下了新的幼崽。

Windsong: We've made pretty significant progress in maintaining this sanctuary, but there's still a lot to be done.
北方哨歌：我们的保育工作很有成效，但是并没有结束。

She points at the map but quickly pulls back her finger, realizing there is still grease on it.
北方哨歌下意识地想用手点地图上的某个地方，但想起自己指尖的熊脂还没干透，便急忙撤了回来。

Windsong: The spot over there—yes, that's the lumberyard. It used to be part of the conservation area, but apparently not anymore.
北方哨歌：就是地图上，那边那个点，木料场，那里本来也属于这群“奥维尼克”的栖息地，但现在已经不适合“奥维尼克”生存了。

Windsong: How long has the sawmill been there?
北方哨歌：那已经建成多久了？

Sofia puts the newspaper down on the table.
索菲亚把刚放在一边的报纸铺了过来。

Windsong: Umm. This newspaper's from last week. Where's the latest one?
北方哨歌：这份报纸是……上周？你看上周的报纸干嘛?

Sofia: You can't be serious, Comrade Ekaterina. The ranger only goes to town once a week for supplies. All the newspapers we have are a week old.
索菲亚：瓦莲京娜同志……只有每周守林人去镇上购买物资的时候，他才会一口气把上周的报纸都带回来。

Sofia: We've been here for months. Did you seriously not notice all this time?
索菲亚：我们在这里调查了这么久，你一直不知道这件事吗?

She looks at Windsong with a hint of confusion.
同伴疑问的目光落到了北方哨歌的脸上。

Sofia: You do seem to care very little about the outside world. You've barely mentioned it since we entered the forest.
索菲亚：这么说来，从进入森林开始，我都没见你问过外界的信息。

Windsong: Ahem. I was totally caught up with those ovinniks, so—
北方哨歌：嗯……因为我在琢磨这群“奥维尼克”的事……

Sofia: They seem to be all you ever want to focus on.
索菲亚：你看上去更像是情愿**只**琢磨这件事。

Throughout this conversation, Windsong has been absent-mindedly drawing on the paper.
北方哨歌无意义地用笔在纸上画着。

Windsong: It's already October, Sofia. How much longer do you plan to stay here?
北方哨歌：索菲亚，现在已经是 10 月初了，你还会在这里待多久?

Sofia: My work here isn't done yet. With the rate of human expansion in the area, it won't be long before they encroach on ovinnik territory. If I leave now, I'm worried the ovinniks here will be left vulnerable.
索菲亚：我的工作还没有结束，人类的扩张其实已经在侵占“奥维尼克”原有的领地了，如果放任不管的话，这个种群迟早还会出问题。

Sofia: I'm planning to set up a new conservation area in the spring—in a place where they and humans won't get in each other's way.
索菲亚：等来年开春，我想去帮它们寻找一个既不会危害到人类，也不会被人类威胁到的地方，让它们安心在那里发展。

Sofia: Then I'll have to make sure they settle in well. So, that'll be about a year from now.
索菲亚：等到确认好它们的情况后，我想那差不多已经是一年之后了，等那时候我再离开。

Sofia: What about you, Ekaterina?
索菲亚：你呢？瓦莲京娜?

Windsong rests her chin in her palm, falling silent.
北方哨歌支起了下巴，长久没有回应。

Windsong: Hm. I'll have to go back to the institute once my paper's done.
北方哨歌：嗯——写完论文我就得回研究所了。

Windsong: If it gets published, people will learn about the critters here, and maybe some will come lend a hand.
北方哨歌：如果顺利的话，这里的魔精生存状况说不定也会被更多的人关注，就像有关特利迦地区的那篇论文一样。

Windsong: Just like they did in Taryga.
北方哨歌：到时候你说不定会多很多帮手。

Sofia: That would be just the help I need.
索菲亚：那可真是帮大忙了。

She walks to the window and looks at the snow outside.
索菲亚走到了窗户旁，看着林间厚厚的雪。

Sofia: The ranger told us we had to leave in two days. They're closing off the area for the winter.
索菲亚：守林员说，最迟到后天，这里就会大雪封山，我们必须离开。

Windsong: Three months. I doubt much has changed back home.
北方哨歌：三个月……即使不会有什么改变，我还是得回去看看……

Following Sofia's gaze, Windsong peers out the window and scans the distant mountains.
年轻的研究员随着索菲亚的视线看向风雪漫天的远方。

Windsong: I wonder if it's already started snowing at the institute.
北方哨歌：不知道研究所那里是不是也在下雪？

8#1
8#1

泡沫之下
After the Bubble Bursts CH18603-06

Removal Worker: Watch out! Make way, please!
搬运工人：嘿，让一让——！

Windsong: What ...
北方哨歌：……这是……

Windsong stands frozen in the entryway. She cannot fathom what she's seeing.
北方哨歌呆立在门口，望着这场她无法快速理解的景象。

With solemn looks on their faces, the police officers before her are carrying equipment out of the building and loading them, one after another, onto their truck.
人们阴沉着脸，一箱一箱的实验器材被警察装上了货车。

Windsong: What's going on?
北方哨歌：这是发生什么了？

Windsong: Comrade Yelena? Comrade Alexei? What's happening here?
北方哨歌：叶莲娜同志？阿列克谢同志？研究所怎么了？

Windsong: Why are the police confiscating our equipment? And why does everyone look so sullen?
北方哨歌：我在门口看见大家都阴沉着脸，警察为什么要带走那些实验器材？

Yelena: You're back, Ekaterina. How are your little critters?
叶莲娜：瓦莲京娜……您回来了……您养活您的小魔精了吗？

Looking weary, Yelena forces a smile.
叶莲娜脸上扯出了一个勉强的笑容。

Windsong: Couldn't be better! The paper's finished, and I've sent it off to the editors. Where is everyone?
北方哨歌：成果显著！我已经把那篇论文寄出去，就等回信了……但是研究所里的人呢？大家都去哪里了？

Yelena and Alexei exchange a glance.
叶莲娜和阿列克谢对视了一眼。

Yelena: Haven't you heard?
叶莲娜：您不知道发生了什么吗?

Yelena: The study of ley lines is no more.
叶莲娜：理线学……已经结束了。

Windsong: No more?
北方哨歌：结束?

Alexei silently hands her a journal. National Nature Studies—Windsong submitted a paper to them not long ago.
阿列克谢沉默着将一本期刊递给了北方哨歌，这正是她寄去论文的那本《国家自然》。

Windsong: What am I looking for exactly? What happened to this page?!
北方哨歌：我看看……呃，这是什么?!

As she flips through the journal, she finds two pages stuck together by red paint.
北方哨歌快速地翻看着期刊，但其中一页被涂上了红油漆，页和页之间粘到了一起。

All she can make out are the features of a familiar face on the unglued edge of the page.
从没粘住的地方能看到一个被狂乱的线条涂住的人像，而人像下面有个理线师们都知道的名字。

Windsong: Tristan Lisov?
北方哨歌：特里斯坦·莱索夫?

Alexei: Sorry, give me a minute. There should be a copy or two that they missed.
阿列克谢：哦，抱歉，我在找，总该有没被怒火波及的期刊。

Yelena: Corruption, bullying, fraud ... He's guilty of all of them.
叶莲娜：学术贪污，学术霸凌，学术诈骗，学术造假……

Yelena shrugs helplessly.
叶莲娜无奈地耸耸肩。

Windsong takes the other copy from Alexei.
接过阿列克谢递来的另一本期刊，北方哨歌又开始翻看起来。

Windsong: "In an abuse of his authority, Lisov manipulated open bidding, misappropriated funds from research projects, and gained millions of rubles in personal profit ..."
北方哨歌：“莱索夫利用科学院专家身份的职务之便，违规操纵科研招标流程，瓜分项目审批资金，从中获得数百万卢布的分成……”

Windsong: "His reputation was built on intimidation and coercion rather than academic merit ..."
北方哨歌：“他在学术界的崇高地位并非来自真正的学术成就，而是通过对同事和研究生的霸凌和威胁获得……”

Windsong: "Through manipulating experiments and tampering with the results, he secured various awards for himself ..."
北方哨歌：“通过使用伪造研究数据和篡改实验结果来欺骗同行评审和学术界的手段，他获得了一连串不当的奖项和荣誉……”

Windsong: He ...
北方哨歌：这……

Windsong: But why would this affect the entire institute?
北方哨歌：但……这只是他一个人的丑闻啊，怎么会牵扯到整个学派呢?

Alexei: When this story came out, every project related to ley lines was put on hold and subjected to investigation. The institute's currently in a state of suspension.
阿列克谢：这篇文章刊登之后，涉及到理线学的项目都被要求暂时停止研究，进行自查或者接受第三方的调查，现在的研究所处于停摆的状态。

Yelena: Have you heard from the editors? No publisher will accept any journal articles on ley lines now.
叶莲娜：您还没有联系过编辑吧？现在已经没有期刊愿意接受理线学的文章了。

Yelena: All the editors and reviewers who ever published a paper on ley lines are also under investigation. We'll probably hear more about them in the coming days.
叶莲娜：之前审阅理线学相关论文的编辑都被带走调查了，说不定过几天还会出几则大新闻。

Yelena: Criticisms are all over the news. People are arguing against and even condemning the study of ley lines.
叶莲娜：现在提起理线学，就只会有抨击和质疑……别的声音是登不上媒体的。

Windsong: What about the Ocean Project?
北方哨歌：那海洋项目呢?

Alexei: The Bureau of Geology's taken it over.
阿列克谢：被地质局接管了。

Windsong: What about Professor Ivanov? And his research?
北方哨歌：教授的课题呢?

Alexei: He's also been taken away for investigation. There was a joint complaint against him from some researchers here. I'm sure his investors weren't too happy about it.
阿列克谢：教授被带走调查了，研究所的人写了联合举报信……一次失败的投资。

Alexei: Yelena and I are leaving too. There's no point in wasting more time here. Ekaterina, I suggest you do the same and find something better to do.
阿列克谢：我和叶莲娜已经坚持不下去了，我们要另谋出路。瓦莲京娜，我劝你也别再研究理线学了。

Alexei: You see those old fogeys over there?
阿列克谢：看到那几个老顽固了吗?

He points to the corner of the room. A few researchers are in quiet discussion, each with a serious look on their face.
顺着阿列克谢指着的方向看过去，有几个人聚在研究所的一角，气氛沉重地讨论着什么事。

Alexei: They're staying. I guess they just can't accept the reality of the situation. You don't want to end up like them, do you?
阿列克谢：他们不肯放弃自己的研究成果，还在这里挨着。瓦莲京娜，你要和他们坐到一起去吗?

A phone rings. One of the researchers in the corner rushes over and picks it up, but disappointment quickly falls upon his face.
电话声在空旷的研究所里格外刺耳，坐在一角的人听到有电话声便激动地跑过去接，然而马上在他脸上浮现出来的却是失望的神情。

Senior Ley Hunter I: Ekaterina? Is Ekaterina back?
高级理线师 I：瓦莲京娜？瓦莲京娜回来了吗?

Windsong strides over to him, a mix of excitement and confusion swelling in her chest. She hears a gentle voice coming from the other end of the call.
北方哨歌快步走过去，接起了电话。电话那头是十分温柔谦和的声音。

???: Hello, is this Comrade Ekaterina?
???：喂，您好，请问是瓦莲京娜同志吗?

Windsong: Yes. Who's this?
北方哨歌：是我，您请讲。

???: Comrade Ekaterina, this is a call from National Nature Studies. Thank you for submitting your work to us.
???：您好，我是《国家自然》的编辑，非常感谢您选择我们来刊登您的学术成果。

???: But we regret to inform you that your paper didn't meet our requirements for publication.
???：但是很遗憾的是，您的论文未能符合我们期刊的发表标准，我们不能发表您的论文。

Windsong looks at Yelena and Alexei, who seem to already know what the call is about. They both shrug.
北方哨歌扭头看向叶莲娜和阿列克谢，他们好像早就猜到电话的内容，无奈地耸耸肩。

Windsong: Why's that? I wasn't aware there were any new requirements.
北方哨歌：为什么？我这篇论文哪里不合格？

???: Firstly, we were unable to verify the accuracy of the data.
???：首先是，我们没办法验证这篇论文的数据真实性。

???: Secondly, we are currently discussing whether we will continue to publish essays related to the study of ley lines. In the meantime, you may approach other publishers for consideration.
???：其次，我们正在讨论理线学是否应属于我们期刊的选题范围，您可以选择别的期刊来发表您的论文。

???: You'll hear more from us once the decision is finalized. We wish you all the best. Goodbye.
???：祝您一切顺利，再见。

Before she can answer, the lady hangs up.
言罢，对面便挂断了电话。

"Beep ... Beep ... Beep ..."
“嘟……嘟……嘟……”

Windsong slowly drops the receiver away from her ear, but she doesn't put it down. She is too lost in thought.
北方哨歌慢慢地将话筒放了下来，却迟迟未将它放回座机上去。

Windsong: Unable to verify the data? Considering other publishers?
北方哨歌：没法验证数据真实性？讨论理线学属不属于他们的选题范围？

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Senior Ley Hunter I: Academic circles no longer acknowledge the study of ley lines, and ley hunters are no longer considered to be scientists, only arcanists.
高级理线师 I：莱索夫入狱后，学术界将理线学的定位也推翻了。现在大家一致认为理线学不是科学，而是神秘学。

Senior Ley Hunter I: They said that it's extremely shallow, even as an arcane subject.
高级理线师 I：还说它是一种……应用面非常狭隘的神秘学。

Senior Ley Hunter I: They said it amounts to nothing more than some colorful lines and fails to offer a substantial interpretation of any phenomena.
高级理线师 I：他们认为，理线学压根没办法称作一门独立的学科，也没办法用理线学的概念来解释万事万物。

Senior Ley Hunter I: But who would claim their subject to be the only answer to all the mysteries of the world?
高级理线师 I：当然不能了，又有谁说过理线学是唯一真理呢？

"Beep ... Beep ... Beep ..."
“嘟……嘟……嘟……”

The ley hunter walks back to his corner. Yelena comes over and gives Windsong a gentle pat on the shoulder.
失望的研究员转身离开了。叶莲娜走了过来，拍了拍北方哨歌的肩。

She takes the receiver out of her hand and gently returns it to the phone. Windsong just stands there, a blank expression on her face.
她轻轻地拿走了北方哨歌手里的话筒，将它扣回到了座机上去，但北方哨歌仍呆立在电话前。

Windsong: Why ... How did we end up like this?
北方哨歌：……为什么?

Windsong: Many things had to be fixed at that time, and even more needed to be closed. I had to stay at the institute for a while.
北方哨歌：为了处理理线学的巨变，我只能暂时留在了研究所中。

Windsong: Some colleagues were held by the authorities for academic misconduct and subjected to punishment and re-education.
北方哨歌：有些人的离开是因为学术不端，他们需要接受一系列的教育和改造。

Windsong: Some left because there were no longer enough funds to support their day-to-day lives.
北方哨歌：有些人的离开则是因为没有了收入来源，生活再也坚持不下去。

Windsong: That included Yelena and Alexei. Yelena found a new job as a typist, while Alexei returned to his hometown and worked in his father's factory.
北方哨歌：叶莲娜和阿列克谢没过几天就离开了，他们一个去做了打字员，一个回到了父亲开的工厂里。

Windsong: They both expressed regret at having ever studied ley lines.
北方哨歌：离别时，他们都对自己曾投身于理线学而感到后悔。

Windsong: Outside the institute, ley hunters are seen as cult members or, even worse, frauds.
北方哨歌：在社会上，人们听到理线师这个词，就像见到了一名邪教分子或者臭名昭著的骗子，他们两个根本找不到什么好工作。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: They really can't wait, can they? To load us into a cannon and blast us into obscurity.
北方哨歌：他们就这么迫不及待吗?

Without any prior notice, on an otherwise ordinary Monday, the property lease of the institute expired.
某个周一，研究所的租期非常巧妙地，或者说是巧合地到期了。

It wasn't until Windsong passed the blockade and walked to the door of the institute that she saw the eviction notice.
绕过一大早便缠好的封锁线，北方哨歌走到研究所的内门时才看到贴在门上的搬离通知。

Windsong: Hm. Looks like the director's wallet is finally as empty as mine.
北方哨歌：看来所长的口袋终于像我的口袋一样干瘪了。

In the past few weeks, she has lived a life much like everyone else at the institute: waiting for letters, writing replies, anticipating calls, and submitting evidence to validate her research.
收信，写信，等待电话的通知，提交各种关于论文数据真实性的证明，北方哨歌和其他研究员们的生活已经逐渐定型。

But today is a little different.
不过今天的流程和以往有些许不同。

Windsong: Please, hold on a second!
北方哨歌：请等一下。

???: Yes? Is there anything else you need?
???：您还有什么事吗?

Windsong: We're planning to move. Please write me back at the new address. I'll make sure to include it in the letter.
北方哨歌：我们的研究所将会搬去一个新的地方，具体的联络地址我会在挂号信中写给您。

???: I will. Have a good day.
???：好的，劳您费心，祝您一切顺利，再见。

"Beep ... Beep ... Beep ..."
“嘟……嘟……嘟……”

Windsong puts the phone down.
北方哨歌恋恋不舍地挂断了电话。

For a moment, she wonders if she had even just conversed with a real person—the words spoken were calm and polite, but also cruel and cold.
对方彬彬有礼的程度时常会让她怀疑跟自己交谈的是一个假人。

Old Nikola: Is there anything else you need to pack, Ekaterina?
老尼古拉：你还有什么要带走的吗，瓦莲京娜?

Windsong: Not really, director.
北方哨歌：没什么要带走的，所长。

Old Nikola: Give me a break. You know I didn't become the director by choice. I'd rather sit behind bars than deal with administrative work.
老尼古拉：请别揶揄我了，我可不想做这个……用坐牢来逃避当所长的责任，真给那老小子赚到了。

Windsong: But you do deserve the title, sir.
北方哨歌：您也总算熬出头了。

Old Nikola: Hmph. It's more of a burden than anything. Ivanov, you old fool.
老尼古拉：哼。瓦莲京娜同志，也就是伊万诺夫也进去了，这差事才能落到我头上。

Old Nikola: Maybe I should just hand in my resignation and let you take the reins. You'll be the youngest ever director of the Ley Line Institute! A promising young woman!
老尼古拉：我要是撂挑子不干了，你可就是理线学研究所史上最年轻的所长了——年轻有为啊!

Windsong: Whoa, no. Let's not get too crazy!
北方哨歌：不不不……

She waves her hands in protest.
北方哨歌连连摆手。

A few people come down the stairs and pass by them. They all wear a gloomy expression.
楼上零散地下来了两三个人，脸色阴沉如风暴前沉重的海。

Old Nikola: Come. Hop on my bike. I'll give you a lift to the new office. It's quite a walk from here.
老尼古拉：走吧，我骑自行车送你，新研究所离这里可不近呐。

They walk to the exit together. The notice board catches Windsong's eye as they pass it.
二人不再相互打趣，齐齐向门口走去。

Windsong: Give me a second.
北方哨歌：等一下。

She approaches the notice board and reaches out a hand.
路过公告栏的时候，北方哨歌叫住了老尼古拉。

Old Nikola: Why? You want to take it with you?
老尼古拉：你想把它带走吗?

Windsong: Yes.
北方哨歌：是的。

Old Nikola: We haven't gotten new bulletins here for a very long time. Look at these. They seem a lot more sensational than I remember. It's almost comical.
老尼古拉：这儿已经太久没有贴过新的公示了……瞧瞧这些项目，当时我怎么没觉得这些东西有这么离谱。

Windsong gently runs her fingers across the board. The paint is starting to peel, exposing the moldy black wood beneath it.
北方哨歌用手轻轻抚摸着这块厚重的白木板，木板跟木板拼接的地方已经开始掉漆，露出了发霉的黑色木质。

Windsong: I never noticed how worn this thing was.
北方哨歌：好像之前没觉得它有这么旧。

Old Nikola: Isn't it funny how things seem to decay faster when they're left unnoticed?
老尼古拉：你听说过吗，人气兴旺的时候，周围的物品也会受到滋润，相反，人气清冷的时候，物品也会破败。

Old Nikola: I read about it in a book of Chinese philosophy—this little trick that time plays on us.
老尼古拉：这是来自昔日好盟友的生活哲学。

Windsong grabs both edges of the bulletin board and looks at Old Nikola.
北方哨歌伸出手掂了掂公告栏，随后站到了它的左边，看着老尼古拉。

Old Nikola: Don't look at me. My back is even more fragile than my ego.
老尼古拉：我的腰比我的自尊心还脆弱，我可搬不了。

Windsong: Are you really going to just leave it here? Look, your old project's still on it.
北方哨歌：您舍得把它丢下吗？您看，这可都是您曾经做过的项目。

She points at the old announcements. Everything still feels so vivid in their minds, as if it happened just yesterday.
北方哨歌在板子上指过几张中标公示，那正是曾经令老尼古拉心生雀跃的项目，仿佛它们立项的时候就在昨天。

But to Old Nikola, they are now a painful memory.
但对于现在的他来说，只不过是一段令人痛苦的回忆罢了。

Old Nikola: Hmph. It may have been a project to you or me, but to Lisov, it was just another way to line his pockets.
老尼古拉：哼，谁知道是不是被人卖了还帮人数钱呢……不知道莱索夫从我这里赚了多少！

Nevertheless, he bends down and lifts the other end of it.
即使如此，老尼古拉还是跟北方哨歌一起将它搬到了新研究所去。

It isn't easy to carry a big wooden board down the icy street. But, slipping and sliding, they finally make it to the office.
在路上打了好几个滑后，北方哨歌终于跟老尼古拉一起把公告栏搬到了新研究所里。

New Ley Lines Institute
新·理线学研究所

Windsong: This place doesn't look very new to me.
北方哨歌： 新……研究所？这里看着可不“新”啊。

She looks around the office as she drags the board inside.
北方哨歌打量着这间破败的木屋，顺手将公告栏拖了进来。

Windsong: The board won't even fit in here. We'll have to move the table to the side to close the door.
北方哨歌： 要想把这块板子放进来，这里的门就关不上了，得挪挪桌子。

"Plop."
“嗒。”

Windsong: Where's that water dripping from?
北方哨歌： 哪里在漏水?

The shabby office is filled with aging furniture, and there is mold growing along the wall. Clearly, water is dripping from somewhere.
墙纸发的霉顺着天花板的水流长到了地面上，地板吱嘎作响，桌椅老旧不堪。

Old Nikola: This is the best place we can afford now. It'll feel like home soon enough, Ekaterina.
老尼古拉： 知足吧，瓦莲京娜，这已经是我能租到的最好的地方了。

Windsong leans her head back, trying to figure out where the leak is coming from.
北方哨歌专心致志地寻找着水滴声的来源。

Windsong: Will this leak be included in our water bill?
北方哨歌： 楼上漏的水算我们的水费吗?

Old Nikola: I don't think so.
老尼古拉： 不算。

Windsong: Then that's good enough for me.
北方哨歌： 嗯，不亏，那就算赚了。

She rolls her neck, sits down at the desk, and looks for the telephone.
北方哨歌也不再管漏水的问题，而是坐到了她的座位上，下意识地寻找起电话的位置来。

Windsong: Just three steps from my seat. Good.
北方哨歌： 三步外的距离……嗯，不算远。

The telephone sitting on the filing cabinet is covered in a thick layer of dust. Windsong doubts if it still works.
积尘的电话静静地坐在不远处的电话柜上，上面的灰尘会让人怀疑听筒是否还好用。

Windsong: Well, can't ask for too much right now.
北方哨歌： 但现在也顾不上这些了……

She wipes the dust off the desk top and turns on the incandescent lamp sitting on it.
她擦了擦并不平整的桌面，拧开了刺眼的钨丝灯。

Senior Ley Hunter II: Director, could we have a word with you, please?
高级理线师 II： 尼古拉所长，请来一下。

With a gentle knock on the door, two researchers pop their heads in.
门外，两名研究员将老尼古拉叫了出去。

Old Nikola leaves the room, but returns quickly.
几人在门外谈了两三句，老尼古拉便回到了座位上。

Old Nikola: They left. Like everyone else.
老尼古拉：他们走了。

Windsong: Yeah. I could hear you from here.
北方哨歌：我听见了。

Old Nikola: Mm-hm.
老尼古拉：嗯。

The farewells are much calmer than she had anticipated.
意料之内的别离比想象之中要更加简短和平静。

She opens her notebook, squinting from the bright lamp light reflected off the pages.
北方哨歌摊开她正在写的实验方法描述，暖黄的灯光刺得她捂住了眼。

Windsong: That corner over there is one wet day away from being a mold farm. It won't be long before mushrooms start growing in our lungs!
北方哨歌：唉……那边的墙角似乎全部都发霉了，用不了多久，我的肺里就会长出蘑菇了！

Old Nikola: Could you be a little more professional, Comrade Ekaterina? The fungi will only give you pneumonia, not lung-mushrooms!
老尼古拉：请专业一些，瓦莲京娜，大多数真菌感染的罪魁祸首都是霉菌——它们长不出蘑菇。

Windsong lets out a long sigh.
北方哨歌叹出一口绵长又无力的气，仿佛将灵魂吹向天花板一般。

Windsong: Do you think there's still hope for us, Comrade Nikola?
北方哨歌：尼古拉同志，这样的日子会有头吗?

His pen stops at this question.
听见北方哨歌的疑问，老尼古拉停住了正在补充论文证明的笔。

Windsong: Comrade Nikola?
北方哨歌：尼古拉同志?

Old Nikola: Are you still working on that Yakutsk paper?
老尼古拉：你还在写雅库特斯克那篇论文的证明吗?

Windsong: Mm-hm.
北方哨歌：嗯。

Windsong: It's been going back and forth between me and the editors for a while now. First they questioned my data, so I submitted my original report; then they questioned my methods.
北方哨歌：起先他们质疑我论文的真实性，后来我提交了原始数据，他们质疑原始数据的真实性。

Windsong: So I sent them all I have. The raw data, the experiment notes, everything. And they still have doubts about it. I had to request a peer review, but everyone who used to study ley lines is gone.
北方哨歌：再后来，我提交了数据记录和实验笔记，他们还是不信，我申请同行评审合作，但理线学的同行已经……没有公信力了……

Windsong: In the end, they just told me they would no longer consider any submissions from the study of ley lines.
北方哨歌：最后，他们直接说涉及理线学的论文不在他们的选题范围内了。

She leans back in the creaking chair, rubbing her eyes with the back of her hands.
北方哨歌靠在吱嘎作响的椅背上，用手背揉搓着眼睛。

Windsong: I just need one chance—one publisher—to have faith in me. That'll dispel all the fear and suspicion! But none of them are willing to give me a shot.
北方哨歌：只要有一家能刊登涉及理线学的论文，别的期刊也会解除对理线学的封锁，但我就是无法突破，每家期刊都对理线学严防死守。

Windsong: All this effort ... Will I ever see one of my papers get published again? Will people come back to study ley lines?
北方哨歌：我们的坚持会有结果吗？我的论文还会有刊登的一天吗？人们还会再看一眼理线学吗？

Old Nikola: You already know the answer, Ekaterina. You just don't want to admit it.
老尼古拉：你已经得到很多次结果了，瓦莲京娜，只是你不接受罢了。

Windsong: How could I possibly admit such a thing?!
北方哨歌：怎么可能这么轻易接受？

Windsong: Don't you refuse to give up too, Old Nik? After all, we're the only two left.
北方哨歌：你不是也认不了这个命吗，老尼古拉，我们可是最后的战友啊。

Old Nikola: What did you just call me?
老尼古拉：你叫我什么？

Windsong: Ehm, director.
北方哨歌：所长。

Old Nikola: Oh, come on!
老尼古拉：得了吧！

They both try to keep a cheerful atmosphere, but, like the mold, their gloom seems to have permeated every corner of the room.
两人都想把气氛变得快乐一些，但悲伤如同水汽一般已经浸入这个房间的每个分子里。

Old Nikola: I don't know, Ekaterina. Perhaps they'll accept your paper next time, or the time after that.
老尼古拉：说不定就是下次，可能是下下次。

Old Nikola: Perhaps you'll find yourself the only one left in this room.
老尼古拉：到时候可能就剩你一个人了，瓦莲京娜。

Windsong pulls her hands away from her eyes, her vision blurry from all the rubbing.
北方哨歌睁开了眼睛，视线因为揉搓还很模糊。

When she sees the room clearly again, Old Nik is nowhere to be found.
等北方哨歌看清的时候，老尼古拉已经不在座位上了。

An icy wind slithers into the room. Through the gap beneath the door, she sees a shadow standing on the other side.
冷风从四面八方倒灌了进来，北方哨歌能从地面与门的缝隙中看到屋外的人影。

"Chk, Chk, Chk ..."
“咔、咔、咔……”

"Sss ..."
“呲——”

Windsong: I've told you hundreds of times that you need a new lighter, Old Nik.
北方哨歌：老尼古拉，你真得该换个新的打火机了。

She sets down her pen and relaxes her shoulders.
北方哨歌握起了笔，但又放下。

Windsong: This drafty old dump! It's always so d**n cold in here.
北方哨歌：这破房间可真够冷的……

Windsong: He never came back to the office, nor did he call. So I never had the chance to tell him ...
北方哨歌：老尼古拉没再来过研究所，也没再打电话来过，所以，我到现在也没有跟他提起——

Windsong: ... that I received two letters addressed to him. Both, unsurprisingly, were rejection letters.
北方哨歌：在我一个人待在研究所的时候，我收到了他的两封拒收信。

Windsong: I'm not sure I would've had the courage to tell him if he ever had shown up, because if I had, he might never have come back again.
北方哨歌：我不敢说，也许我说了，他就再也不会来了。

Windsong: Regardless, he never came back in the first place.
北方哨歌：虽然……他也确实再也没来过。

8#1
8#1

守夜人
The Night Keeper CH18603-07

Windsong: I'd lost count of the number of rejection letters I'd received. I had long since run out of money and had been sleeping in the office for some time.
北方哨歌：在我收到了不知道第多少封拒收通知，提交过不知道多少次数据证明之前，我就付不起房租，只能住在研究所了。

Windsong: That was my last day at the institute.
北方哨歌：而今天，也是我的最后一天。

Windsong: It's hard to say what the final straw was. Maybe it was my last coin dropping down through the sewer grate or the ink freezing because I added too much water to it.
北方哨歌：也许是因为我一不小心把最后一枚硬币掉到下水道了，也许是因为我兑水兑了太多次的墨水结成冰了。

Windsong: Or maybe because there wasn't a publisher left that I hadn't tried to contact.
北方哨歌：也许是因为我真的再也找不到一家能游说的期刊出版社了。

Windsong: Regardless, there came a time when I decided that if I got one more rejection letter, I'd leave that place for good.
北方哨歌：总之那天，我决定，再接到一封拒收信我就真的放弃，但我不知道我还要在这里等多久。

Windsong: I waited and waited. You know, silence is its own message.
北方哨歌：因为有些时候，没有通知就是一种通知。

Windsong: *sigh*
北方哨歌：唉……

Windsong leans her elbows on the table. The room still smells of mold and damp.
北方哨歌趴在桌子上，一股潮湿的味道迎面而来。

She gets to her feet—there's really nothing better to do anyway. She paces around the room, and as she passes the notice board, a wave of worry washes over her. What is she going to do with it?
百无聊赖，北方哨歌走到了那块公告栏旁，盘算着如果她离开了，这个厚木板要怎么处理。

???: Is Ekaterina here? I have a letter for her!
???: 瓦莲京娜！信！

The mailman's voice rings from outside the door. Windsong's heart sinks.
院子里响起了邮差的声音，北方哨歌心底一沉，无奈地坐在桌子上。

She doesn't move, reluctant to see the contents of the letter. It is slid through the gap under the door.
她不愿意主动去迎接这件事的到来，但是信会从门缝中飞进来。

She picks it up and opens it, just as she has done hundreds of times before.
北方哨歌机械地剪开了信封，从里面拿出了一张纸。

Windsong: "Thank you for submitting ... We regret to inform you ... Best regards."
北方哨歌：“非常感谢……很遗憾……祝您一切顺利。”

Windsong: No need to read the rest.
北方哨歌：看到这几个词就知道又被拒绝了……

She examines the ink; it's clear it comes from a high-quality printing machine.
北方哨歌看着手中的拒收信，油墨光鲜亮丽，一看就知道出自很好的打印机。

She already has a huge pile of letters of the same quality.
只需要一眼，北方哨歌就在破旧的研究所里找到了它的同类。

Windsong: This place is nothing but a ghost town—the shadow of a great era.
北方哨歌：是啊，我们祖上也是富过的。

A sudden rage boils up in her chest. She smashes the letter onto the board.
北方哨歌心头燃起了一股无名怒火，她“啪”地一下把拒收信贴在了公告栏上。

Windsong: So this is it!
北方哨歌：这就是理线学……

She strides back to her table and whips out the rest of the letters.
北方哨歌快步走到了座位上，将之前积攒的拒收信一并拿了出来。

Windsong: This is where it dies!
北方哨歌：这就是理线学！

"Bam!" She slams another.
“啪！”又是一张。

Windsong: "The 21st century belongs to the study of ley lines!" Come out and say it to my face, you traitor!
北方哨歌：不是很风光吗！21 世纪，不是理线学的时代吗！

"Bam!"
“啪！”

Windsong: All that boasting about "ley lines and quantum physics" ...
北方哨歌：理线学和量子。

Windsong: "Hot springs" ...
北方哨歌：泡温泉。

Windsong: ... and "the great Ocean Project"!
北方哨歌：海洋项目！

Her rejection letters now cover the entire board, completely hiding the bulletins announcing those once glorious projects.
北方哨歌把拒收信都贴在了那些曾经风光的项目公示上。

Windsong: You should be the one to swallow this bitter pill! These rejection letters should've been yours, not mine!
北方哨歌：这些拒收信，都是你们该收的！不该是我！

But it is her name that is written on every letter.
但每张拒收信上都写着“瓦莲京娜”的名字。

Exhausted, she collapses to the floor.
北方哨歌无力地坐在了地上。

Windsong: Not mine ...
北方哨歌：不该是我……

Tears well in her eyes and fall on the paper in her hand.
泪滴滴落在了她手中的拒收信上，那上面早就遍布泪痕。

Windsong: All us researchers—all the people dedicated to the study of ley lines—put so much time and effort into our work. And now we're all forced to either move on or starve to death.
北方哨歌：如果没有那些埋头研究的人，理线学不会欣欣向荣起来，但现在专心研究的人寸步难行，纷纷离开……

She tightly grips the letters in her fist, along with the two addressed to Old Nikolas.
北方哨歌攥紧了手中的拒收信，这其中，当然也包含老尼古拉的那两封。

Windsong: If we hadn't had people who were willing to attend social events and academic meetings, we never would've gained respect in academia. But now they're all in jail, and our reputation is utterly ruined.
北方哨歌：如果没有那些四处逢迎的人，理线学的名号也不会这么快打响，但他们都锒铛入狱，名声尽毁……

She looks around at the dilapidated office. It's nothing like those once bustling and prosperous days.
北方哨歌看着破旧的研究所，早就不是以前那般富丽堂皇、人声鼎沸的景象。

Windsong: We're certainly not the only discipline controlled by bullies and scholars undeserving of their status. So why were we the only discipline to be brought down by this?
北方哨歌：别的学派并非没有学阀欺压的现象，为什么单单是理线学如同纸做的老虎，因为……

Windsong: Because ...
北方哨歌：因为……

Windsong: *bitter smile*
北方哨歌：呵……

It's too cruel to say it.
北方哨歌心中早有答案，但她说不出口。

Windsong: Neither the people who bury themselves in research nor the people who popularize it can save it.
北方哨歌：所以，对一个学派来说，埋头研究的人没有用，长袖善舞的人也没有用。全都没有用。

She sits on the floor, her palm still throbbing from being slammed against the bulletin board.
北方哨歌颓然地坐在地上，手掌微胀，有一层麻麻的感觉浮在皮肤之上。

Windsong: Then how am I going to turn the tide?
北方哨歌：我一个人，怎么可能力挽狂澜……

For a long time, she just sits there, paying no attention to the mold on the floor or the ruptured floor boards.
北方哨歌就这么坐在地上，不管地板的钉子是不是翘起了一角，不管板下的蘑菇是不是已经被自己压碎。

She hates to just leave. But what else can she do?
她不想就这么收拾行李离开，但是除此之外她已经没有别的事情好做。

She looks up at the notice board that is now towering over her.
北方哨歌将头靠在桌子上，仰视着那个公告栏。

Windsong: Let the study of ley lines end here, in this cold pit, to die with my career.
北方哨歌： 理线学的历程……今天……就跟我的学术生涯一起……死在这个破屋子里吧……

She stares at it until her eyes are completely dry, unable to shed any more tears.
不知道这么看了多久，北方哨歌的眼泪渐渐流不出来。

Windsong: I can't do this anymore.
北方哨歌： 好累……

As the light in the room dims, she drifts into sleep.
随着屋内的光线渐渐变暗，她迷迷糊糊地睡了过去。

"Ring—"
“叮铃铃——”

Windsong: Hmm?
北方哨歌： 嗯?

"Ring—"
“叮铃铃——”

She quickly scrambles to her feet.
北方哨歌一个激灵，从地上站了起来。

"Ring—"
“叮铃铃——”

She isn't dreaming. It's the telephone ringing.
不是错觉，是研究所的电话响了起来。

She wipes her face on her sleeves and picks up the phone.
北方哨歌快速地擦了擦脸，连忙把电话接了起来。

???: Hello. Is that Ms. Ekaterina?
???: 喂，您好，请问您是瓦莲京娜女士吗?

Windsong: It's me. Who's calling? Is that the editor?
北方哨歌： 是我。是期刊的编辑吗?

She holds the phone tight against her ear, not wanting to miss a single word.
北方哨歌把话筒紧紧贴在耳朵上，她期望事情发生转机。

???: No, this is Sofia.
???: 不，我是索菲亚。

Windsong: Sofia?
北方哨歌： 索菲亚?

Her memories of Yakutsk come rushing back.
记忆回到了雅库特斯克，明明一直在修改这篇论文，但索菲亚的名字已经变得有些陌生。

Sofia: Yes, it's me. Now that the weather's warming up in Yakutsk, would you like to come back and continue our research?
索菲亚： 是的，现在雅库特斯克的气温已经回暖了，我想邀请你来继续我们的研究。

Windsong: Research?
北方哨歌： 研究……

She looks around the office. The mold has crept its way to the center of the ceiling.
北方哨歌看着这个破败的新研究所，霉菌已经蔓延到了天花板的中央。

Windsong: Have ... Have you heard about what happened here?
北方哨歌：你……不知道理线学发生了什么事吗?

She asks the same question that Yelena and Alexei asked her on that fateful day.
就像当初的叶莲娜和阿列克谢，北方哨歌也向索菲亚发出了警告。

Sofia: A little bit here and there. I've also heard you've had a tough time getting your paper published. I'm in a bit of a jam here—there's too much work for one person. Would you like to come and lend a hand?
索菲亚：我知道，我也察觉到你的论文发表得并不顺利，但我这边一个人进展不下去，所以可以请你过来吗?

Windsong: But, the study of ley lines has been ...
北方哨歌：可是……理线学已经……

Sofia: Whatever happened, does it matter now?
索菲亚：跟理线学发生了什么没有关系吧?

After several moments of painful internal struggle, Windsong speaks again.
北方哨歌犹豫再三，还是说出了自己心中的担忧。

Windsong: Your research might be disregarded if they find out you're working with a ley hunter.
北方哨歌：如果有理线学的介入，你的魔精保育计划也会被人视为欺诈项目的。

Sofia: It's still better than stopping altogether. There are critters' lives at stake.
索菲亚：这会妨碍我们的研究吗?

Windsong: I-I'm not sure about this.
北方哨歌：我……不知道。

Sofia: You can figure the rest out when you're here, Comrade Ekaterina.
索菲亚：那你快来吧，瓦莲京娜同志。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong: Aren't you worried about what people might say?
北方哨歌：你不在乎吗?

Sofia: They've got nothing to do with our study, Comrade Ekaterina. You should focus on a more compelling subject.
索菲亚：那些事都与研究无关。瓦莲京娜同志，我觉得你的注意力应该放在更有趣的事情上。

Windsong: ...!
北方哨歌：……!

Sofia's determined tone surprises her.
理所当然的语气令北方哨歌微微一愣。

Windsong: Sofia, you ...
北方哨歌：索菲亚，你……

"You should focus on a more compelling subject."
“我觉得你的注意力应该放在更有趣的事情上。”

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

She feels a bitter sorrow in her throat.
宛如敲响的圣钟驱散了阴霾，这几个月的酸楚涌来，堵住了北方哨歌的喉头。

She holds the receiver tightly in her hands, as if she's holding her dear friend.
她紧紧地捧着电话，犹如抱住了这位远方的友人。

For a moment, a genuine fear grips her. What if all this is just a dream?
她怕她放开手，就会失去这份对理线学来说尤为珍贵的接纳。

Tears well in her eyes again. They drop on the desk top and glisten like the morning frost.
滴落在积尘的电话桌上的泪水慢慢结成了冰。

Windsong: You are right. We ... We should meet in Yakutsk.
北方哨歌：你说得对。我们……应该在雅库特斯克见面。

Her fingers ache from the clenching, but she is determined not to let go.
北方哨歌的语气平稳。她的手指和小臂一阵酸痛，但还是不愿意减轻自己力度。

Windsong: Yakutsk. I can't wait to go back.
北方哨歌：雅库特斯克，我的“别洛沃耶”之地，那场让我想要永远沉迷的梦境。

Windsong: I have to pull the study of ley lines out of this cold grave.
北方哨歌：我得以继续下去的理线学……它不会在这间屋子里消亡。

Windsong: I won't let it die like this.
北方哨歌：我不会让它在这间屋子里消亡。

Once again, she looks at the notice board.
北方哨歌看向贴满了拒收信的公告栏。

Her heart feels lighter. Finally, there is a new path before her.
她突然觉得心底出现了一个新的答案。

8#1
8#1

同行者
Companions CH18603-08

The hall is silent as the researchers listen intently.
银白色的研究员们安静地听着北方哨歌的讲述。

Windsong takes a sip of water before speaking.
北方哨歌拧开了一瓶水，轻送进嘴里一口。

Windsong: By now, perhaps you have your answer to my question.
北方哨歌：在座的各位听众，也许现在你们也得到了自己的答案。

Windsong: When it comes to a school of thought, who do you need more—those that get the work done or the ones that make it popular?
北方哨歌：对于一个学派来说，是埋头研究的人更重要，还是长袖善舞的人更重要?

A shiny metal arm sticks out from the audience.
一只银白色的手臂在稍暗的观众席中抬了起来。

Windsong: Yes, the comrade in the back.
北方哨歌：这位同志——请。

Researcher III: The root of the problem in your story seems clear.
研究员 III：通过您讲述的故事我们能很轻易地得出一个结论。

Researcher III: The decline of the study of ley lines was caused by those who exploited it for personal gain.
研究员 III：正是因为理线学的学派中有太多只想利用理线学满足私欲而不专心研究的人，所以理线学才会覆灭——

Researcher III: So the people you need more are those who truly care about the subject.
研究员 III：所以我觉得还是埋头研究的人更重要。

The answer is quickly refuted.
但马上有人提出了异议。

Researcher VI: But the study of ley lines always lacked a proper barrier to entry. The composition of researchers was quite diverse and rather loosely defined.
研究员 VI：难道不是因为理线学并不是一门正经的学科，所以才会有这么多不务正业的人吗？

Researcher III: Had there been no one to actively publicize it—those people who worked to build its respectability—hardly anyone would've taken it seriously in the first place.
研究员 III：如果没有那些善于逢迎的人，那理线学的知名度我想也不会这么高。

Researcher V: "Those people"? It was Lisov alone who made the subject famous. I heard he was even invited to teach in some other countries.
研究员 V：它的知名度和那些无名之辈没有关系，是因为莱索夫，我听说，他的名声大到当时是有人希望他去到另一个国家的。

More and more people join the discussion. Windsong has to raise a hand to return order to the room.
自发参与讨论的人越来越多，北方哨歌不得不维持一下秩序。

Windsong: Thank you, thank you all.
北方哨歌：请安静一下。

Windsong: I understand where each of you is coming from, but my answer differs slightly from yours.
北方哨歌：各位说的都有些道理，但我最后得出来的答案和大家想的都不太一样。

Windsong: Before the session started, a pair of comrades came up to me and asked two questions: "Why are you still working on ley lines?" and, "What made you stay?"
北方哨歌：在演讲开始之前，有两位研究员问过我几个问题，总结来说就是，你为什么还在研究理线学？理线学有什么值得研究的地方？

Windsong: What is the study of ley lines, exactly? Is it a science or an arcane subject?
北方哨歌：它算科学还是神秘学？

She types the words "science" and "arcanum" on the screen.
北方哨歌走到了投影的正中央，打下了“科学”和“神秘学”这两个词。

Windsong: Today, most of it has been buried in the sand.
北方哨歌：当我们现在来评价理线学的时候，它就像一个埋葬在永冻土下的冰封古国。

Windsong: People can only conjure a vague image of it through stories or records.
北方哨歌：我们只能通过一些历史的片段，那些概括性的文字，来推断它，为它设下定义。

Windsong: So, is it a science? Sadly, there's no doubt it's under the category of arcanum.
北方哨歌：站在现在的角度来看，理线学算科学吗？很遗憾，与它刚被建立时的定位相反，它是彻头彻尾的神秘学。

Windsong: To many people, ley lines are not even an objective phenomenon, nor are they consistently verifiable.
北方哨歌：对于很多人来说，它并不算客观现象，不存在可检验的解释，也无法被公式化。

Windsong: Many theories regarding ley lines can't even be cross-examined using scientific methods.
北方哨歌：它的理论也并不普适，有很多结论我们没办法用目前科学的手段给予证明。

She shakes her head ruefully.
她遗憾地摇了摇头。

Windsong: Yet its arcane nature is not a sin or the reason for its decline.
北方哨歌：但属于神秘学并不是理线学的原罪，这不是它现在如此衰落的原因。

Windsong: No, it was undermined by the high hopes that people held for it. They wanted it to be the ultimate solution—the answer to all their questions. It was doomed to disappoint them.
北方哨歌：理线学的症结在于，它被给予的期望太高了，人们将它当作万物之理，企图从它这里得到一切的答案。

Windsong: It had its heyday—it even flourished. Many believed it to be the path to our next great advancement.
北方哨歌：它如同能够使人前往云端巨人之国的豌豆茎一般狂野生长，欺骗人们为了这个美好的愿景犁遍了理线学的土地。

Windsong: Until the dream was shattered by the cold reality.
北方哨歌：但事实告诉人们，理线学中并没有他们想象的所罗门王般的智慧。

Windsong: It's an arcane subject with a very narrow application. It could never stand on its own two legs as a specialized field of study.
北方哨歌：它只是一个应用面很狭隘的神秘学学科，甚至它必须要依靠别的学科的知识才能够得出一些结论。

Windsong: People abandoned it because it didn't offer the solution they sought.
北方哨歌：所以人们的离开也无可厚非，因为人们想要的答案并不在这里。

Windsong: It had drawn too much attention it didn't deserve in academia.
北方哨歌：理线学过早地登上了本不该属于它的学术殿堂。

She sees a few nodding heads in the audience.
台下，有人在默默点头。

Windsong: But I think every researcher, no matter their field, is an explorer, wandering wherever the truth may lie.
北方哨歌：但是我想，不管是哪门学科，研究者的本质都是在真理的荒原上到处乱窜的探索者。

Windsong: We could go in the wrong direction, get lost in the wild, and start all over again.
北方哨歌：即便是方向错了，我们还是能够回到原来的地点，选择一个前所未有的方向，重新出发。

Windsong: This is the point we're at with the study of ley lines.
北方哨歌：理线学现在就处于这个需要重新出发的状态，而我，我就是那个因为失败而回到原点的人。

Windsong: This time, I hope to find a new path for it. It may be rough, muddy, and full of danger, but we must take the first step.
北方哨歌：我想带领理线学走出一条默默无闻的小径，这条路可以坎坷，可以泥泞，但我认为它必须存在。

Windsong: There have been many breakthroughs and advancements in the last few years, and I sincerely congratulate you all on these achievements.
北方哨歌：这些年，我们已经见证了太多次技术和理论的突破，我为各位同仁在各自领域取得的成就感到由衷的敬佩和欣慰。

Windsong: And I always hoped you would think of this path whenever a mountain stood in your way.
北方哨歌：我也一直心存着一个希望，那就是假如哪天你们碰到了不可逾越的高山，或许也可以回头看看理线学这条小径。

Windsong: Perhaps it could be a detour, leading you to the destination.
北方哨歌：看看它是不是可以帮助你们绕过高山，抵达绿洲。

Windsong: This is why I'm still here, as the last ley hunter.
北方哨歌：这是让我一直坚守在这里的理由之一。

Windsong looks at the first researcher.
北方哨歌看向演讲前对她提出疑问的那个研究员。

Windsong: Let's go back to my question. When it comes to a school of thought, who do you need more—those that get the work done or the ones that make it popular?
北方哨歌：让我们回到刚才那个问题："对于一个学派来说，是埋头研究的人更重要，还是长袖善舞的人更重要?"

Windsong: The truth is, I think neither of them are that important.
北方哨歌：我想其实这两者都不重要。

Windsong: But Sofia made me realize that the only way to keep the subject alive is to let people see it for what it truly is—to understand it and acknowledge it.
北方哨歌：索菲亚的话让我明白了，当一个学派即将走到尽头的时候，只有让更多的人看到理线学，认同理线学，它才有可能会继续留存下去。

Windsong: Networking and connection-making won't keep the subject alive, and if we only focus on writing academic papers, we'll soon find ourselves in financial trouble.
北方哨歌：能为学派带来利益交换的并不能构成学派的核心，而埋头苦学者同样不等同于拥有足够的天赋。

Windsong: For now, they're both unimportant to the study of ley lines.
北方哨歌：我想，对于现在的理线学来说，这两种人都是不重要的。

She pauses, giving the audience a moment to process the information.
北方哨歌停顿了一下，给台下的听众留有足够的思考时间。

Windsong: No, what it really needs is a genius, one that can extend the path and bring our study to another level, so people can see its true value.
北方哨歌：是的，理线学需要一位天才，一位能够开辟出更幽深的路，让其他研究者们发现理线学别有天地的天才。

Windsong: Like Newton to physics, Einstein to relativism, Watson to biology.
北方哨歌：只有他才能够真正的拯救理线学，复兴理线学，就像牛顿之于力学，爱因斯坦之于相对论，沃森之于生物学。

Windsong: Maybe the genius we need is among us in this very room.
北方哨歌：而他也许就隐藏在听讲座的你们之中。

Windsong: This is the other reason why I stay in this field.
北方哨歌：这是让我一直坚守在这里的理由之二。

Windsong: I hope that people will learn about ley lines from the reports I've written and the projects I've participated in.
北方哨歌：我相信，从每一份实验报告中，从每一篇有理线学参与的论文中，我的坚守能够让更多人了解真实的理线学。

Windsong: I will keep walking this path.
北方哨歌：我会一直在学术之路上行走。

Windsong: And I hope to see you all along the way.
北方哨歌：我也衷心希望在座的各位研究能够顺利，学术之路能够长远。

Windsong: That concludes my lecture. Thank you.
北方哨歌：非常感谢各位的到来，我的讲座就到这里，谢谢大家。

She bows to her audience.
北方哨歌向台下深深地鞠了一躬。

"Clap, clap ..."
“啪、啪……”

At first, there are just a few scattered claps. But the applause quickly turns thunderous.
掌声逐渐零散地从观众席各处响起，然后汇成了一道巨河。

Office, Laplace
拉普拉斯科算中心办公室

Administrative Staff: Ms. Windsong, please wait here. Madam Lucy will join you in a moment.
行政人员：北方哨歌小姐，请您在这里稍等一会，露西女士马上就到。

Windsong: Sure.
北方哨歌：好的。

The staff member puts down a bottle of water and leaves. Windsong looks around the empty office.
行政人员放下一瓶水后就离开了，办公室里暂时就只有北方哨歌一个人。

Windsong: Never thought a lecture could be so tiring.
北方哨歌：原来演讲是一件这么耗费精神和体力的事。

She pulls over a chair and sits by the window.
北方哨歌拖来了一把椅子，将它拉到窗前，坐了下来。

At times like these, she finds herself thinking of Rayashki ...
一个人的时候，北方哨歌还是会想起那片雪海。

... the people who embraced the study of ley lines from the beginning, and the people who saw her as family.
想到那个刚从绝境中走出来的镇子，想到那群从一开始就接纳了理线学的人们。

Windsong: To think that a "Storm" could take away a world. It's almost too absurd to be true.
北方哨歌：一场“暴雨”，带走了一整个世界……荒谬，却是事实……

There are strange footsteps coming from the hallway. Windsong looks toward the door.
不一会，走廊里发出一阵奇异的脚步声，北方哨歌将视线挪到了办公室的门口。

"Knock-knock."
“叩叩。”

Without waiting for an answer, the door is opened.
办公室的门直接被推开。

Lucy: Sorry to keep you waiting, Ms. Windsong.
露西：久等。北方哨歌女士。

As soon as she enters the room, Lucy plugs herself into the power socket.
机器人来到这里的第一件事，就是将自己的充电线连接上电源。

Windsong: Madam Lucy, thank you so much for inviting me here to give the lecture.
北方哨歌：露西女士，很感谢您邀请我来举办这场讲座。

Lucy: The pleasure is ours. I believe you have many questions to ask, including about the "Storm" in Rayashki.
露西：我想，你应该有很多希望我解答的疑问，其中包括来亚什基的那场“暴雨”。

Windsong: Yes, ma'am.
北方哨歌：是的，露西女士。

Her face turns serious.
北方哨歌的表情严肃起来。

Windsong: What exactly happened to Rayashki and its people?
北方哨歌：来亚什基的人们，他们身上……究竟发生了什么事情?

Lucy: It was not just Rayashki. The entire world has been wiped out by the "Storm."
露西：不止是来亚什基，而是整个世界——他们都被“暴雨”回溯了。

Lucy: To put it simply, the world they lived in has been reversed to a time before its existence.
露西：简单来说：时间倒退，世界回到了一个他们还未诞生的时间点。

Lucy: Would you feel better if I put it this way, Ms. Windsong?
露西：北方哨歌女士，这种解释会让你感到好受一些吗?

Windsong: If I made it sound like we still have a chance to undo all this?
北方哨歌：会让我觉得一切尚可有挽回的余地……您是否在安慰我?

Lucy: It is true that we may have found a way to stop it from happening again.
露西：这不是安慰，但事情确实仍存在好转的可能。

Lucy: We have people here using every ounce of their knowledge and every means possible to find a way to end the occurrence of the "Storm."
露西：因为有人将穷尽世界上所有的知识，用尽一切手段，来找到终结“暴雨”的办法。

Lucy: That is also the purpose of Laplace.
露西：拉普拉斯科算中心正是为了终结“暴雨”而存在，我们为此从不懈怠。

Lucy: We need your knowledge, Ms. Windsong. We need your help to end the "Storm."
露西：我所使用的“所有”和“一切”，其中自然也包括理线学，北方哨歌女士，我们需要你的知识。

Windsong: To end the "Storm"?
北方哨歌：终结“暴雨”?

Her voice carries a bitter amusement.
北方哨歌哑然失笑。

Lucy: Your heart rate and body temperature indicate that you are having an emotional reaction. Are you angry, Ms. Windsong?
露西：你的心率和体温告诉我你现在的情绪波动很大，你很生气，是吗?

Windsong: I missed my only chance to save my friends.
北方哨歌：……我错过了唯一一次拯救同伴的机会。

Lucy: That was not your only chance, Ms. Windsong. I am not asking you to end it yourself. I am only requesting a ley line report on it.
露西：那不是唯一一次，北方哨歌女士，而且，你有个误区，我不是要你去终结它，而是分析它，这才是“理线学”的长处。

Lucy: More "Storms" will come, and we need you to help us see them clearly.
露西：你还有很多次机会，你可以把握住从此以后的每次机会，用理线学将“暴雨”看个透彻。

Lucy: We will eventually find a way out of the "Storm."
露西：直到我们找到办法主动走出这片雨幕。

Lucy: And when that time comes, we will find the person with the means to end it.
露西：至于“终结”的部分，会有更合适的人去做。

Windsong unclenches her fists.
北方哨歌松开了她掐出凹痕的手。

Lucy: That is why I am inviting you to join Laplace. We need your expertise to improve our chances of putting an end to these tragedies.
露西：所以我向你发出这份邀请，我希望你能将理线学的力量贡献出来，为解决“暴雨”增添一丝可能性。

Lucy: Laplace will fund your project. More people will hear about ley lines, the stories behind them, and also the story of you, Ms. Windsong, the last ley hunter.
露西：科算中心也会支持你的研究，在我们的影响下，理线学将被更多人提起，它急速的膨胀和衰败，惊天的丑闻，以及最后一名理线师，北方哨歌女士。

Lucy: We cannot change the past, but we can decide the future.
露西：毫无疑问，你是连接理线学过去与未来的那个节点。过去的事你无法改变，但你可以把控它未来的走向。

Lucy: The future. It is such a beautiful word in humans' eyes, and they attach to it the most wonderful fantasies.
露西：未来……人类认为未来是美妙的词语，他们不吝于把最美妙的幻想都放在它的身上。

Lucy: It will not be easy to have the future of the study of ley lines resting on your shoulders.
露西：肩负起理线学的未来，这真是件不轻松的事。

A light flickers across the slit on her face.
露西的显示屏闪了一下。

Lucy: However, you have done an exemplary job so far, Ms. Windsong.
露西：不过，北方哨歌女士，你已经在这条路上走了很远了。

Windsong: ...
北方哨歌：……

Windsong hears the ring of a telephone. An echo in her mind.
不存在的电话铃声在她的脑海中回荡。

She takes a step forward and extends a hand.
北方哨歌走上前去，伸出了她的手。

Windsong: I accept your invitation.
北方哨歌：我……接受您的邀请。

She smiles, looking into what she believes to be the robot's eyes.
她抬起头，注视着对方本该存在着双眼的位置，露出了一个微笑。

Windsong: I look forward to working with you, Comrade Lucy.
北方哨歌：期待与您一起努力的日子，露西同志。

8#2
8#2